



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 26th June, 2025

The House met at 3.08 p.m.

[THE SPEAKER IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, I would vary the order of the day. I would like us to take the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICAL REPORT**

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would start with the correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 25th June, 2025.

Page 1...9 —

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, the name [*inaudible*]

The Speaker: Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 10...15—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, let me walk you to the item numbered 3(v), “Organiser, Ghana Online Driver Union”. I should be grateful if “Driver” is made plural and same be done to the

item numbered 3(vi). If you take notice, the item numbered —

The Speaker: Hon Member, that is right. There must be consistency.

So, Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 16...20—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, page 20, the item numbered 3(xii), “Ms Juliet Abena Babilah, Sister In-Law of the Nominee...”, I think it should be...

3.18 p.m.

The Speaker: Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 21...27

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 25th June, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

I have a copy of the *Official Report* of Tuesday, 17th June, 2025. Any corrections? Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Bismark Tetteh Nyarko: Mr Speaker, let us go to the last paragraph of column 62. In the spelling of “Dafeamekpor”, the “a” before the “m” was omitted. I believe my Leader is on another duty outside the Chamber, and that is why I have to draw your attention on his behalf. Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, thank you, Hon Member. Office of Chamber Reporting, kindly take note. Are there any further corrections?

Mr Afriyie: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Column 10, the very last line of the third paragraph, I think the proper rendition of the Ministry as we now have is Ministry for Environment, Science and Technology. So, we could delete the word “Innovation” that has been attached to it.

The Speaker: Yes, Office of Chamber Reporting, kindly take note. Any more corrections?

Hon Members, in the absence of any other corrections, the *Official Report* of Tuesday 17th June, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Let me acknowledge the presence of some of our distinguished visitors, particularly, our partners and leaders now studying in various institutions. We have students from the La-Nkwantanang M’A ‘2’ Basic. They are 61 in number, and are being led by Agnes Azantilow, who is the headmistress. The school is located at La-Nkwantanang, Madina.

On behalf of the Members of Parliament, I warmly welcome you to your House, the Parliament House, and express our joy in seeing you here. Please, you are encouraged to come more, because if you are caught young, you are likely to do better than we are doing today. I believe that is the objective of every parent or leader. So, you are welcome.

I have been reading this name from time to time, Agnes Azantilow. I think you are doing very well, and you should be commended. Thank you so much for always bringing your students to

Parliament. Please, you may resume your seats.

The MP for Madina is not available. He is at a Committee meeting.

[Pupils from La-Nkwantanang M’A ‘2’ Basic were acknowledged]

We have again, another group of students from La-Nkwantanang, M’A ‘6’ Basic. They are 59 in number, led by their teacher, Maud Aboagyewaa. The school is also located at La-Nkwantanang, Madina.

I want to once again warmly welcome them too, to the House of the People, Parliament House, and to encourage them to keep on coming. I also want to thank the teacher for leading them here.

When I called your name, you recall that Members had some good memories of that song. It is only those who are old enough who know it. Those who are young may not know that song. But it was sung by a beautiful police lady and I am not about that one. *[Laughter]*— We used to dance with it a lot. So, you are coming from a famous school. The lady is leading you here. Congratulations. Please kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils from La-Nkwantanang M’A ‘6’ Basic were acknowledged]

We have a team of seven, led by their Country Director by name Anita Amoako-Gyimah. They are called Projects Abroad and they are coming from Madina Constituency. Where they are coming from, I do not know. But now, if you want to look for them, I am

sure you will see them in Madina. The name “Projects Abroad” means they may be coming from outside Ghana.

Which countries are you coming from? United Kingdom? Are all of you coming from United Kingdom? That is good. You are coming from a monarchy. Welcome to a democracy. *[Laughter]*—This is the House of democracy in Ghana. We were under your monarchy. Now we are independent and we are happy that you are here to support us to develop. We are extremely grateful. Please keep on coming. We want to learn a few from you, just like how you also picked some from us. Please take time and see what we do here. It may be similar to yours, but not exactly the same. You are warmly welcome. Kindly resume your seats.

[The Team from Projects Abroad were acknowledged]

We have another group; the Pentecost Preparatory School and they are 87 in number. They are led by Pascal Zanu, a teacher.

3.28 p.m.

They are coming from Upper Denkyira East. You are warmly welcome. I think Members should applaud the efforts of the teacher—*[Hear! Hear!]*—That is quite a large number, 87. The cost involved would be colossal and I hope the Member of Parliament would contribute her quota. Is the Member available?

Ms Emelia Ankomah — rose —

The Speaker: Congratulations, you have done well. Please, you may resume your seats. You are lucky your Member of Parliament is a lady. You see what Hon Ladies can do? What the Ladies can do, the Gentlemen cannot do. If you want, contest her; she has brought 87. Let me see how many you can bring. It is a test. I am watching you. Please, congratulations.

[Pupils of Pentecost Preparatory School were acknowledged]

The Speaker: We have another group coming from Apedwa Presby Basic School and that definitely would be from the Abuakwa South Constituency. They are led here by the headmaster, Thomas Tenadu Asirifi. They are 61 in number. Please, you are also warmly welcome. What I observed about the 61 is that they are younger than the rest – very young pupils from Apedwa Presby Basic School. Congratulations on coming and we wish you all the best. We have staff readily available to take you through a number of the rudiments of parliamentary practice. So, find time to go round with them. Please, you may resume your seats.

[Pupils of Apedwa Presby Basic School were acknowledged]

The Speaker: Hon Members, I have a Statement to make and I want Members to make remarks on this Statement. It is a Statement that I believe is good news for Parliament and the Parliamentary Service. It is a Statement on the institution of Speaker’s Scholarship by the Nobel International Business School

(NiBS) University. It is for Parliamentarians and staff of the Parliamentary Service.

STATEMENT BY THE SPEAKER

Institution of Speaker's Scholarship by the Nobel International Business School.

The Speaker: Hon Members, kindly indulge me to make this Statement in recognition of a treasured scholarship which Noble International Business School, (NiBS) University, Africa's premier doctoral school, has instituted for Members of Parliament and staff of the Parliamentary Service on my behalf.

As Hon Members would appreciate, university education is the cornerstone of national development, since it equips people with the requisite knowledge and skills to innovatively surmount intricately complex socio-economic hurdles to spur development. Harbison (1973) would have us believe that human resources are the active agents of production who accumulate capital, exploit national resources, build and develop social, political and economic organisations that plan and implement national development programmes.

A country which is unable to develop the skills and knowledge of its people and to utilise them effectively in the national economy would be unable to develop anything else. Universities are at the centre of training the human resource requirement of a country for progress. Hon Members, not only does university

education equip graduates with the highest possible knowledge, practical skills and skills in the Master's speciality, but a university education is a creative spirit, one which injects the blood of humanism and culture into the youth.

In modern times, universities focus on innovative pedagogy with sound human values. As a developing country, Ghana badly needs high-skilled human capital. Therefore, these institutions of higher learning are key to the socio-economic development of the country. Not only does the country rely on research findings from universities for important decision-making, the human capital developed by these universities lead the development efforts of all sectors. However, the attempt of Ghana at enhancing university education is often derailed by challenges, not least among them inadequate funding for public universities. As a means of increasing access to university education, the Government of Ghana formed the University Rationalisation Committee in 1987, charged with the mandate to develop proposals for reforming the management, academic structure and funding of tertiary education in the country.

Based on the report of the committee, Government issued a white paper in 1991 which boosted the establishment of private universities in the country. This led to the proliferation of private universities to the extent that their total number exceeds 100 today. Certainly, the blossoming of private university education is good for the development of the country since public and private

universities share a common goal and that goal is to provide quality education as espoused in Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 4.

Hon Members, one of the leading private universities in the country which has contributed significantly to the human resource sets of Ghana, including Parliament, is NiBS University, a presidentially chartered institution accredited by the Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) and the British Accreditation Council. Founded in July 2014, the university is a member of the Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business. Some of its flagship programmes of study are

3.38 p.m.

- i. Public Sector Innovation and Leadership Programme.
- ii. Dr of Business Administration (DBA).
- iii. Doctor of Business Leadership (DBL).
- iv. Executive Master of Business Administration (EMBA).
- v. Master of Business Leadership (MBL).
- vi. Master of Fintech Management (MFM).
- vii. Master of Public Sector Innovation and Leadership (MPSIL).
- viii. Master of Science Design Management and Leadership (MSDML).

Since its establishment, NiBS University has graduated very illustrious sons and daughters of this country, some of whom are Members and former Members of this august House.

On 18th June, 2025, I had the rare privilege of hosting in the Sir Charles Emmanuel Quist Conference Room, a high-powered delegation from NiBS University led by the founder, Prof Kweku Atuahene-Gyimah. The delegation presented to me a proposal for the institution of a scholarship dubbed Speaker's Scholarship for Parliamentarians and Parliamentary Staff. The Scholarship was established in recognition of what the University describes as my:

“Inspirational and transformational leadership and commitment to Ghana's democratic and institutional development.”

And my,

“Visionary leadership and pivotal role in promoting academic advancement and capacity building among Parliamentarians and staff.

The Scholarship covers various graduate programmes of study with attractive monetary values as follows. One, PhD in Business definitely will give you US\$7,599. Two, Doctor of Business Leadership, US\$6,999. Three, Doctor of Public Sector Innovation and Leadership, US\$5,599. Four, Doctor of Business Leadership, US\$6,999 and various master's programmes which will give you US\$1,399 each.

It is expected that these scholarships from NiBS University will promote lifelong learning among Members of Parliament and staff of the Parliamentary Service, strengthen policy research and legislative analysis, and bridge the gap between academia and governance. This partnership between the Parliament of Ghana and NiBS University is also expected to build a legacy of knowledge and impactful delivery of services under my leadership.

The proposed Speaker's Scholarship will provide from the indication I have given, 20 per cent tuition scholarships to Members of Parliament and Parliamentary Service staff who apply—And note this one; who apply through official endorsement by the Office of the Speaker of Parliament. *[Hear! Hear!]* Again, underline it; subject to good behaviour.

[Laughter]

Some of you are already disqualifying yourselves. Are you admitting that you are not of good behaviour? Please make an attempt to be of good behaviour. I will be very objective in my assessment as to what I understand by good behaviour. So, you all qualify, except you disqualify yourself. I want to call on all Hon Members and staff of the Parliamentary Service to take full advantage of the Speaker's Scholarship for Parliamentarians and Parliamentary staff to be empowered with degrees that wield innovation and offer the type of leadership that prepares Parliament to meet the expectations of the good people of Ghana.

On behalf of the Parliament of Ghana, let me wholeheartedly extend a resounding gratitude to Professor Kwaku Atuahene-Gyimah, president and founder of the university. I also extend the same to the faculty and the entire NiBS community for this generous offer. Hon Members, we had to do a similar thing with the Ghana Institute of Management and Public Administration (GIMPA) some years ago under my leadership then as the Minority Leader and a number of Members and staff took the opportunity to build up their capacity and that strengthened Parliament in the performance of its functions. I pray that the current group of Members of Parliament and Parliamentary staff will also take advantage of this offer from NiBS University.

With this, Hon Members, I thank you for your listenership. I will now give you the opportunity because some of you are graduates of that university. I was given the list of a number of Hon Members and staff that have gone there to obtain a PhD. So those of you who want to say a few words about the university, please you may kindly do so now. Those of you who want to change your behaviour to qualify, you may kindly also give me notice so that I start assessing you. Because without my recommendation, the school will never give you that scholarship; that is what is communicated to me.

Yes, Hon Member?

3.48 p. m.

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah (NDC — Berekum West): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to comment on this

very important Statement. I rise to commend the management of the NiBS University for this important opportunity for the Members of Parliament and the Parliamentary Service staff to pursue postgraduate education.

Mr Speaker, I would also like to commend you for your exemplary leadership that has culminated into this opportunity for members of staff and Members of Parliament. On that very day, I listened carefully to the praises showered upon you by the founder of NiBS University.

Mr Speaker, with your leave, I would like to quote one important statement he made, he said, he is “giving this opportunity to the Members of Parliament and the members of staff as a result of your deft handling of the legislative affairs of the Eighth Parliament, when some of the most advanced democracies could not survive the hung Parliament”. I think this commendation is very important for us to recognise.

Mr Speaker, I must say that the development of every nation depends on the quality of human resource and not on the abundance of natural resources. It is therefore important as legislators of this country to have this opportunity to pursue postgraduate education. On that note, I would like to urge Members of Parliament and the Parliamentary Service staff to take this opportunity to have a postgraduate education.

Mr Speaker, I want to end by saying I am going to be one of those who will be applying and that is why I have

conducted myself very well since being sworn into office. I am very confident that I will catch the eye of the Speaker when he is awarding this opportunity to members of staff and Members of Parliament.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Member, may I get your name?

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Kyere-Duah: Mr Speaker, my name is Dickson Kyere-Duah, the Member of Parliament for Berekum West in the Bono Region.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Berekum West?

Yes, I have taken notes.

Hon Member, your Chairman is up, so let me give the Chairman the opportunity to see whether he will also qualify. *[Laughter]*

Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I am more than qualified. Thank you for the opportunity and let me also thank you very much for inviting me to join you in receiving our august visitors when they called on you.

Mr Speaker, I listened to them very carefully and in analysing what they said, I would want to add that they mean very well and they mean business. They are not like the people who would come and make promises and will not fulfill them; but I hope they will do so.

Mr Speaker, as you rightly said, the private universities in the country are contributing very much to capacity building. Research has shown that for every single student at the private university in this country saves the government GH¢50,000 a year. This is because government will have found it very difficult to find space for this number of students in the public universities, pay lecturers or faculty and provide other teaching and learning materials. So, we have to applaud the role being played by the private universities in this country and NiBS is one of them so they deserve our commendation.

Mr Speaker, what is important for us to do as I listened to you is about timing. Because the information available, as you rightly said, that GIMPA had been in this business with Parliament before and some of the Members of Parliament who started the programme could not complete it because of time. And in this case, I would like us as Members of Parliament to look at the timing for lectures and other activities.

Mr Speaker, you set up the Parliamentary Training Institute and it could be a lecture hall for Members of Parliament, where the lecturers from the university could come down and have lectures with students in Parliament. So the Parliamentary Training Institute could be used as one of their lecture halls and I hope when this is done, we will be able to get many people.

Mr Speaker, our longest recess is between August and October. So I would also like to suggest that that period

should be used as a contact period for students who will benefit from the facility. Mr Speaker, we are grateful to your involvement in ensuring that Members of Parliament are comfortable to do their work well. The training that you have given us so far and also the love you have shown us so far is what has brought this arrangement and we are grateful to you. We also join you to thank the management of NiBS University for this gesture.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Well noted.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Please, the Hon Member in front of you.

Offinso North, right?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

First, I would like to commend you for this initiative. In fact, I was proud of the first orientation you gave us as freshers when we came in to embark on in this hallowed Chamber. It really added up onto our knowledge and skills and that is what tertiary education or higher education is about; improving on one's competence, skills base, and one's ability to do specialised stuff. So, Mr Speaker, congratulations and thank you.

I would also like to congratulate NiBS University for this collaboration with the Parliament of Ghana. Mr

Speaker, it would interest you to know that I am currently offering a programme at NiBS to also add up to my skills because one can never stop learning. I am trying to look at the entrepreneur ecosystem and the performance of the pharmaceutical industry vis-a-vis innovation and strategy. So, this is something that I am personally proud of and excited about.

Mr Speaker, the previous government embarked on ensuring that we increase our gross tertiary enrollment ratio to 40 per cent. With this gross tertiary enrollment ratio, Mr Speaker, studies have shown that the more graduates one has in terms of economic returns, increases as compared to primary and secondary education. Currently, as a country, we are blessed to encourage all young ones to get primary and secondary education. If we want to improve on our economic returns globally and nationally, then, Mr Speaker, the best way to go is to make sure we all can afford tertiary education.

Mr Speaker, one thing you are doing that I am also proud of is that this hallowed Chamber decides on most of the things that happen in this country. We decide on what even the Executive can do; we even set the laws for the judiciary to use to adjudicate.

Mr Speaker, once you have embarked on this journey, I would like to encourage — for instance, as legislators, when we go to Committee meetings, compared to other jurisdictions, where they have researchers who support them on every decision they make and every statement they make on the floor or in

committee meetings, unfortunately, in our system, we have one Research Assistant who helps a Member of Parliament with Committee on Education, Committee on Health, and Committee on Economy and Development.

3.58 p.m.

What kind of research and skill base do they have to support the decisions that we are using to inform the legislation aspect of our work? Mr Speaker, as we are appreciating and glorifying you for this collaboration with NiBS, I will be happy if we could also rope in as many of our research assistants who would want to be part of it to improve on their knowledge base. This is so that we can have researchers who are timely, relevant and have all the knowledge base to support our development as a nation.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is sitting at the centre of the world. We have rich people and people who have enough knowledge, skills and the ability to do everything that we want to do in this world. It may interest you to know that we have Ghanaians being the heads of cardiothoracic centres across the world. What can we not do? The only way we can do this is to ensure that as many Ghanaians as possible, can afford tertiary education. So even as we are also doing this, we can also encourage the Government to, as much as possible, give all the support that it can to private tertiary institutions.

As a member of the Committee on Education, we embarked on a field visit and we realised that many Ghanaians

would want to have higher education but the ability to do so is not there, not because they cannot learn, but because they cannot afford it. Mr Speaker, I want to stand on behalf of all Members of Parliament (MP) to say we are grateful. Let us encourage as many of us that would want to continue higher education, improve their research skills and expand their brain. We realise that by the time we die, we would not have utilised even up to 10 per cent of our brain cells. The more we learn, the more the brain expands. Thank you, Mr Speaker and congratulations.

The Speaker: Did you say you are the MP for Offinso South?

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, Offinso North. I was even in your office today.

The Speaker: All right. Offinso North, that is Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah.

Dr Asamoah: Yes, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Congratulations. You are already there so you do not need my recommendation. Yes, let me take one from the Majority Side. The Hon Member stood up and I asked him to give the opportunity to the Chairman. I will come to the Ladies, but let me listen to the Hon Deputy Minister for Education. Where are you now?

Deputy Minister for Education (Dr Clement Abas Apaak): Very well, Mr Speaker. I am the Deputy Minister for Education. Mr Speaker, I am most grateful to you for giving me the opportunity to add my voice to this wonderful Statement that you made on our behalf, in appreciation of this generous offer made to you in our name.

Mr Speaker, let me say off the bat that NiBS University is accredited, for the sake of the records. Mr Speaker, I think the decision to name the scholarship, the Speaker's Scholarship for Parliamentarians and Parliamentary Staff, is apt. I believe anyone who has followed Ghana's Fourth Republican Democracy and Rt Hon Speaker's activities and contributions, will not be surprised that this noble institution deemed it fit to come to the Rt Hon Speaker to make this offer and to propose the most legitimate title, as far as this scholarship opportunity is concerned.

Mr Speaker, having commended you, it is only proper that we also recognise that NiBS University has shown generosity. In many ways, we could say that this is an example of corporate social responsibility that is worthy of emulation. Private universities have and continue to play an important role in helping the state to fulfil its responsibility of ensuring that citizens have a right to higher education.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Education has held a meeting with the leadership of Ghana's private universities and as his Deputy, I was privileged to be in that meeting. The Minister is fully cognisant of the key role that private universities play and has committed to supporting them to even do better. Some of the issues that came up at the meeting had to do with accreditation. The Minister is committed, and is working with Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) to ensure that the processes towards accrediting private universities are streamlined.

The Minister is also considering extending the student loan to Ghanaians who are going to take up places in private universities. The Minister has even gone ahead to announce a package to support private universities to train faculty. Clearly, the Minister and Government recognise the important role that private universities play, now more than ever, when we consider the significant numbers of students who are completing secondary school and juxtapose that with the failure of the state to appropriately prepare spaces for these huge numbers of students at the tertiary level, which includes universities. So, the Government is committed. The Minister is already working to ensure that private universities continue to play their role and even do more.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I commend you highly, for this scholarship which has partly come to benefit us because of your good works, deeds, and the record that you have set. We are forever indebted to you and may God bless you. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: He does not need the scholarship at all, so he is not going to apply. I know him very well, so I know he does not need it. It is some of you who are struggling to qualify.

Dr Apaak: Mr Speaker, some of them are interpreting it to mean I am not of good behaviour. *[Laughter]*

The Speaker: No, you do not determine that; I determine that. He has not put in an application, but he is of good behaviour. That one, I can for sure

attest that he is of good behaviour. Yes, since the Leader is up, I will give him the opportunity. Then after that, our Hon Member for Ada will have her bite.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP—Weija/Gbawe): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, we first need to commend you and the Noble International Business University for this great partnership. Mr Speaker, education, we know, is the bedrock of one's major development. We are aware that without education, most of us may not even have had the opportunity of getting here. We also know that education is very expensive in recent times, especially, for private universities. When parents are served with fees, we can understand what people go through. Mr Speaker, for some of us, we understand that this is the time for people to take advantage to have some development, training, and education. That is why we believe that this is the best of platforms, especially, for Members of Parliament who may want to pursue further education, to avail themselves for such a very fine opportunity.

Mr Speaker, we are looking at it from an angle of what we are going to do as Members of Parliament who are going to benefit from such a great initiative.

4.08 p.m.

First of all, would we get curricula that is demand-driven? Are we going to get curricula that is tailor-made to suit our times and periods, so that as

Members of Parliament, we can be here and there at the same time and that would give us the opportunity to have proper output and, in fact, proper input and output?

Mr Speaker, respectfully, in all these arrangements, we request that this should not be coterminous with your tenure as the Speaker; we are looking at the fact that when you are not here tomorrow, that should be a legacy. That the Rt Hon Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin had this scholarship for Members of Parliament and when you are no more, even after 36 years, we can still say that that is a scholarship that is inscribed in your name.

Mr Speaker, we are looking at the sustainability of this. I believe that with all the good works you are doing, this is a conversation you can consider and have with the owners of Noble International Business University. Mr Speaker, for me, what is more important is that you will not forever be a Speaker, but you can once upon a time be a Chancellor, a Chancellor of NiBS University. Mr Speaker, as a Chancellor, what you can do for some of us is to open the forum for us to also have some sort of partnerships beyond Ghana. So, NiBS University would not just be a university from Ghana but one that has other relationships with other universities, like the University of Oxford, University of Cambridge and Harvard University, so that people can have all manner of programmes they can attend.

Mr Speaker, with this, I think that this is a very commendable initiative. It is a

partnership that is worthwhile, and we need to commend you and commend NiBS University.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I just want to say, thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, well noted.

Yes?

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Mr Speaker, first of all, I would like to thank you so much for this wonderful gesture, because this is an opportunity that we are all looking for and you have brought it to us in Parliament.

Mr Speaker, we are all interested and are ready to learn. We are ready to sharpen our brains. Already, Parliament is a place where one can learn from archaeology to zoology and you have introduced this too, which is a plus.

Mr Speaker, all that we say is, thank you so much and do not forget to write our names because we are all ready. We will sit, read, learn and do the good work. Mr Speaker, when you get the one that we can learn law, bring that also; we are ready. So, that we will all be lawyers, learn the law and work properly for our constituencies. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Members, definitely this is leadership by example. She is not stifling the young ones. The fact that she wants to go and study does not mean she is taking the opportunities away from the young ones. This is leadership by example.

I told you when I was the Minority Leader, I had to lead the team to the Ghana Institute of Management and Public Administration (GIMPA). I was personally there to study. Out of about 42 that got enrolled, 17 completed. So, what the Chairman of the Education Committee stated is real experience and we would take that into consideration. That time we did not have such space in Parliament for tutorship; now, we have. So, we will talk and discuss with them to see what could be done with our Parliamentary Training Institute (PTI), the collaboration between Parliament and the University, and how to time the courses to suit the time of Members.

It is not easy, but life is not easy. So, you have to study. If it is possible and you would want me to lead you, I will lead you. [*Hear! Hear!*] I will enrol. Not under the scholarship because that is for Members of Parliament and staff of the Parliamentary Service. I am not a Member of Parliament, neither am I a staff of the Parliamentary Service; so, I am disqualified. But I have to qualify those who are qualified—[*Laughter*]*—It will be a legacy for the House. Whether I am Speaker or not, those succeeding me will continue and we believe that it will be sustained.*

So, please, let me take another contribution from this Side. We have some other work to do.

Some Hon Members — *rose* —

The Speaker: Are you part of the Majority? This is because some of you are here and I do not know whether you are right or left.

Mr Kumah: Mr Speaker, the Majority extends up to this side. We are part of the Majority. Mr Speaker, Kintampo is part of the Majority.

The Speaker: Yes, you have been on your feet for some time, so let me allow you. I will come to you, my Sister.

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to have a bite on this important issue.

Mr Speaker, my Chairman, most of the Members, and Leadership have already spoken. I just want to add other aspects of the needs that, as a House, we need to help formulate policies to help our private universities to be able to cope with the numbers that are being churned out, looking at Government policy to send a lot of students to the private senior high schools this year. We should be looking at how to enable some of the private universities to also be able to absorb those students in future into the university, so that enough space will be created.

Mr Speaker, I happen to be a Member of the Committee on Education who went around for a number of weeks. Mr Speaker, to add to the assertion by my Chairman, that the research that shows each student that a private university—saves Government about GHC50,000.00. The reality of what is happening there is that most of the private universities are beginning to be on their knees in terms of cost.

Mr Speaker, if you remember All Nations University, the university that

brought Ghana to the limelight, the space travellers' university, your Committee visited that university. We went to KAAF University College, Wisconsin International University College and other ones. Mr Speaker, their cost of operation is becoming so high that as policy makers, we should begin to look at what Government can do to save them.

We are looking at the loans they use to operate some of the universities. If Government can come in to reduce or talk to banks to reduce the cost of borrowing. They mentioned that President Kufuor and President Atta-Mills of blessed memory, supported some of them with school buses by our Act, the Ghana Education Trust Fund Act, 2000 (Act 581). I am sure they are not supposed to benefit from the GETFund support. What can we do, as a House, to let them benefit, now that a lot of students are coming into the system?

Mr Speaker, having said this, I am sure it is an important issue that, as a House, we should begin to look at, so that our private universities will come up. If we look at the facilities they have, the unique programmes and courses that some of them have and have started running, such as Artificial Intelligence and others, even the government universities do not have.

4.18 p.m.

We need to encourage them in that light. I am grateful, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to this.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to your Statement. In fact, your Statement is a very big source of motivation and encouragement. Learning is not about age, because learning has no end. Learning is not about how many years, degrees, or whatever you have, no. Learning is about interest and adding more knowledge to yourself is very important. Mr Speaker, if this encouragement had come earlier, I believe that even people who have left Parliament and are no more MPs would have benefited a lot. I am not surprised when I listen to you, when you lead us in discussions and when you present Statements to us, I realise that you do a lot of reading. You learn a lot and that alone is a form of motivation. This is the same thing that you are putting across to us. For some of us, we are ready and we will participate.

We will ensure that we learn and we will make good use of what we learn from the motivational words and encouragement that you have brought us. But I want to buy the idea of the Chairman of the Education Committee that in order for us to be able to participate and make judicious use of our time, the lectures should take place in Parliament here. It will help us a lot. Even if we have activities, we know very well that at a particular time, we would be at lectures and at the time that is required for us to come in and work as Legislators, we would come to do that.

Mr Speaker, another request was made about our personal assistants and our research assistants. These are people

who are assisting us in our work as MPs, but most of them find it difficult to further their education maybe higher than their MPs. I will appreciate and wish to plead that they should be included in this innovation that you have put in. With the Parliamentary staff, I wish to say that please get encouraged. Maybe some of us eventually will not be MPs. Some of you can even come in and be MPs. So why not?

We need to learn hard not only for ourselves but even for our grandchildren. Because when you learn, you will definitely impact knowledge if only you take the trouble to do that. So Mr Speaker, I thank you very much. I wish you the best and I wish that you continue to encourage us and to ensure that we learn properly and that you lead us so that we do not even do courses that may worry us because we have individual differences. So, I thank you very much and I hope that what we have discussed will be taken aboard. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Well, you can see this Hon young lady who just spoke. She is a living example of lifelong learning and she has really impacted a lot on her constituents. That is why you cannot beat her in her constituency. Yes, because she is always learning and she has been here for long. I knew her very well before she even came here and I know where she came from. So please take advantage of it.

Yes, I think the young man behind you should have a bite. The Leaders should alert me when they are ready.

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East): Thank you, Mr Speaker for acknowledging me. Mr Speaker, I would like to start by adding my voice to the numerous commendations that are coming to you. I know this opportunity that NiBS University is offering us has not come by any mean feat but it has come through dint of hard work, your exemplary leadership and the pace that you have set throughout your entire life. And I think we have just looked at you, the father that you are, thinking about your children and giving us this opportunity to also excel.

Mr Speaker, let me also thank NiBS University for this privilege. I have actually been there to enquire and I was there to enquire on the Doctor of Public Sector Innovation and Leadership and looking at their facilities, Mr Speaker, I saw that they have a really conducive place for learning and their times that they gave are also flexible. Other Members have also indicated the chance to have their studies in Parliament. If that comes, that will be a plus. But if it does not happen, we still have a very conducive place that we can conduct our studies.

Mr Speaker, I also realised that usually doctoral programmes are very long and sometimes it takes between four to six years. What I realised from the enquiries that I made and from other people who had graduated and had their doctorate degree from the same place was that because of the intensity of the programme and the willingness of the facilitators to make sure that we

complete early, it does not take so long for you to complete that programme. And I realised that notable personalities like Dr Ransford Abbey and other people. I even realised that about three MPs here have passed out from the school and we even have a Deputy Clerk, Dr Gloria Sarku Kumawu. She also had a doctorate degree from the same place.

Mr Speaker, I think it is in a very good light that you have afforded us this opportunity. We are very grateful. And I would like to end by saying that a few of my Colleagues are interested in this offer. I am only wondering how many slots are available because we are quite a lot. We are also behaving very well in Parliament. The interest is high, so I think you need to continue to impress upon them to expand the slots so that it can accommodate a lot more MPs. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

The Speaker: Yes, that is the MP for?

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Mr Speaker, MP for Kwabre East.

The Speaker: All right, MP for Kwabre East, the early bird catches the worm.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: You have done very well, so you are eligible to qualify.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Dr Sebastian Ngmenenso Sandaare:

Thank you very much Rt Hon Speaker, for the opportunity. I rise to make a few remarks on this very important scholarship. Mr Speaker, listening to you, I got excited that the significance of this scholarship programme by NiBS University is about rewarding you, Mr Speaker, for showing leadership of integrity.

Mr Speaker, there are so many young ones that look at you and they want to be like Speaker Bagbin. Looking at you and studying about you, starting as a Member of Parliament up to the seventh Parliament, becoming the Speaker for the Eighth Parliament and still the Speaker for the Ninth Parliament, you have demonstrated that you are the leader that we can all emulate to be and that is the significance of this scholarship.

4.28 p.m.

Therefore, the many Members of Parliament and staff of the Parliamentary Service, that would want to take advantage of this scholarship programme, should know that it is not just a scholarship to attain a degree in Masters or PhD, but it has significance that one must be a leader of integrity and a leader with values like yourself, Mr Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin.

Mr Speaker, I know that the Leader Bagbin would never die. When I say would never die, what it means is that you would live and your name would live like Dr Kwame Nkrumah, and that is the significance of this scholarship. So, we

are grateful to you for being a leader, an exemplary leader, to many young ones and to many of us who look up to you and say, yes, we are proud that you have demonstrated the values.

Again, Mr Speaker, not to be tribal, but you have demonstrated that you were trained as what the term *pepe nii* meaning, *p3p3*. Your values would live forever. And I believe it is these values that the NiBS University has seen and want to train many more leaders in this country that will lead like the Speaker Bagbin. Thank you very much for the exemplary leadership, and thank the NiBS University for seeing these leadership qualities in you and granting this scholarship to Parliament. I am grateful for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Thank you. I think we would take the last comment. There are a lot of interests, but we have to move on. So, Leaders, I think if I should take the young man to my left, we should call it a day. Then, the First Deputy Speaker would take over because I have a delegation in my conference room waiting on me. Or you want to have a bite?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, I would prefer to rather yield to Dr Kabiru.

The Speaker: Thank you.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, I want to join my Hon Colleagues in thanking you for this great initiative, and to also thank NiBS University for the opportunity for Members of Parliament to add quality to

themselves, to the debate of the House and to add quality to national discourse.

Mr Speaker, as we rightly put, education is a lifelong activity and one can never get to its end because every day we learn. However, I would like to share, based on personal experience that I had the privilege of doing my PhD seven years ago. Seven years, almost a decade of continuous learning is something that I would say Members of Parliament should not allow the opportunity to slip by.

Mr Speaker, I am very young in this House, but the most difficult lessons I have learnt is that most Members of Parliament, aside their personal endeavour, are not able to do any work when they leave the Chamber. The opportunity to add quality to themselves, would serve as a livelihood for each Member of this House in the event they are not interested in legislative duty.

Mr Speaker, pursuing a PhD, is an opportunity to add to one's skills of research. Consultancy comes handy. If one pursues a PhD, even in our universities, one is very well positioned to contribute and impart knowledge to our upcoming generation. So, bringing it at this time, at a time that Members of Parliament are even looking to see whether after politics, what is in store for them, it is very timely and worthy of commendation. I think it is an opportunity that we must take absolute advantage of.

Mr Speaker, the other courses, as it were, the Masters programme that they could pursue, but the most significant for

me and for most Members of Parliament and Parliamentary Staff, is the PhD.

Mr Speaker, it is difficult for a Member of Parliament to combine the tedious and laborious exercise of having to perform the oversight expected of him and at the same time learn. But Mr Speaker, it would be worth the sacrifice and I think that such Members, under your leadership, should be considered, sometimes, for a leave of absence, if the need be, for them to focus on doing the research that is required. And I know that, under your leadership and with your approval, Members would find it handy to be able to do this exercise.

Mr Speaker, but I would further, like Oliver Twist, like it is said, say that, when it comes to this particular opportunity, let us give opportunity again to those of us who are still budding, like in the popular saying “catch them young, and they shall be yours forever”.

Mr Speaker, your legacy would be enduring. You have a lasting legacy, even after your generation, your grandchildren would come to learn that a young man from Kwabre East got an opportunity to learn or to pursue PhD, and that PhD has helped him to impart knowledge in society.

Mr Speaker, I am urging that those of us who are coming, it is an opportunity for us to be caught young, so that when we learn and we acquire this degree —

Mr Speaker, there is one trend that I am sure is not yet within the Chamber and within your force. There is this particular trend of people having

unending PhD and Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) is raising issues.

Mr Speaker, this is a timely opportunity for us. Those of us who are interested in it should grab it and legitimise whatever position we have. Therefore, when we do that, we are adding respectability to this House, and that Members of Parliament work hard to earn their PhDs.

With this, Mr Speaker, I want to thank you once again, and to thank NiBS University for this brilliant and great opportunity.

The Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me assure Hon Members that I put a very high premium on this offer from NiBS University. And so, we will do everything we can to support Members of Parliament. But more importantly, the Staff, to build on their capacity. In the 8th Parliament, under my leadership, we have been able to get seed capital, which is available, to build the capacity of Staff and Members of Parliament, which we believe will add a lot of value to our democracy and our development. And so, under the new leadership that we have here, the Majority Leader and Leader of the House, we have also reached out to the research institutions; all the research institutions, and they have agreed to have focal researchers to Parliament. So they will be attaching researchers to support what we have in-House, to assist Members and the Committees on research findings and data that is available for you to take for evidence-based decision making. So, we have taken some steps towards beefing up that area.

We will have to look at the GETFund Act. Definitely, it should not be restricted to only public universities but it should be extended to private universities too. So, if the public sector, that is the Executive, is too busy with other matters, Members, try the Private Members Bill and let us look at it.

4.38 p.m.

We would do the fiscal impact analysis and we will see whether what we are going to do will add to or rather reduce the cost to Government.

I will also encourage Members—It is just going to take about three years. We are in the first year of the Ninth Parliament of the Fourth Republic. If you take advantage of it, by the time you get to the next election, you would be a PhD holder. Who knows, if the Lord does not smile on you, you will be capable of taking care of yourself. You know what is happening to those who have left. It is a golden opportunity that you should not allow to slip by. As I said, if you even say I should lead the way, I will go myself. Those of you who are going to be, not only of good behaviour, but focused and hardworking, I will personally contribute to pay for the cost of your education in the University. *[Hear! Hear!]*—I will do so with all my heart because we need you. We need you to do better than us.

We, those who started in January 1993, are now 33 years. We do not expect that you should be trying to emulate us. We expect you to perform better than us. That is evidence of development. If you are still looking up

to us, then we have not gone far at all. We should be looking up to you, because you are now surpassing what we have done. So please, I encourage all of you take advantage of it. As I stated, it is going to be a legacy. It will not end with my Office. It will continue when my successors come to Office. So please, take advantage of it and I am sure with further discussions and negotiations with the University, we can make things easier for Parliament, the University, and the staff, to make sure that we improve the human resource capacity of Parliament and of our country.

Yes, I see the Minority Chief Whip wants to say something.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am grateful for your indulgence. Mr Speaker, just to corroborate the points you made on the inclusion of private tertiary institutions in the Ghana Education Trust Fund Act, 2000. I think it is a welcome news. It should not just be left there. We have to pursue it to its logical conclusion.

Mr Speaker, not too long ago, the Scholarship Secretariat, formed in 1960 and was limited to the Presidency, had now been decentralised and it was a good measure. I recall at the National Union of Ghanaian Students (NUGS), we advocated for Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT) to rope in private tertiary institutions. It was a back-and-forth issue but eventually, we were able to achieve that. Now SSNIT is not limited to only public universities. Private tertiary institutions have also been —

The Speaker: Hon Member, please, First Deputy Speaker to take the Chair.

4.42 p.m. — [MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, just to support and to corroborate the point that roping in private tertiary institutions is long overdue, and it is a matter that should not be wished away. We should not just listen to it and allow it to die a natural death. We could probably even refer it to the Committee on Education to go into it and get some conclusions on this matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minority Chief Whip.

Yes, Majority Leader, do we continue with Statements?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations is here. So, let us take his Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations is here to respond to Urgent Questions. So, we move to the item numbered 6. The first Urgent Question stands in the name of Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, Member of Parliament for Effutu. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I come under Order 88(3), with the authority of the Minority Leader, and further seek your permission to ask the Question for him on his behalf?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, permission is granted.

URGENT QUESTION

MINISTRY OF COMMUNICATION,
DIGITAL TECHNOLOGY AND
INNOVATIONS

Circumstances that Necessitated the Closure of Some Radio Stations

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh on behalf of (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin) (NPP — Effutu): I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the circumstances that necessitated the closure of the following radio stations: (i) Fire Group of Companies, Sunyani, 90.1MHz; (ii) I-Zar Consult Limited, Tamale, 89.7 MHz; (iii) Abo Channel Media Group, Adidome, 105.7MHz; (iv) Okyeame Radio Limited, Bibiani, 99.7 MHz; (v) Mume Bono Foundation, Techiman, 99.7MHz; (vi) Osikani Community FM, Nkrankwanta, 99.7 MHz; and (vii) Gumah FM Station.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations (Mr Samuel Nartey George) (MP): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The six FM stations were directed to cease operations on 18th February, 2025, by the National Communications Authority (NCA) because they did not have valid authorisations as required by section 2(4) of the Electronic Communications Act, 2008 (Act 775). The

stations were Fire Group of Companies Limited operating on 90.1 MHz in Sunyani, I-Zar Consult Limited operating on 89.7 MHz in Tamale, Abo Channel Media Group operating on 105.7 MHz at Adidome, Okyeame Radio Limited operating on 99.7 MHz in Bibiani, Mume Bono Foundation operating on 99.7 MHz in Techiman and Osikani Community FM operating on 99.7 MHz at Nkrankwanta.

It is important to note that prior to taking the enforcement actions, Mr Speaker, all the affected FM stations were given the opportunity to renew their expired authorisations, but they failed to do so.

However, the authorisations granted to the seventh radio station, Gumah and Sons Limited, to operate a commercial FM station at Bawku on 104.9 MHz was suspended on national security considerations based on a request from the Ministry of the Interior acting on the advice of the Upper East Regional Security Council.

However, Mr Speaker, all the other six radio stations have since resumed operations after they rectified their infractions. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, let me thank the Minister for the Answer duly provided. Can the Minister apprise this House—I concede he is giving a general nature of infractions. Can he give us the specific infractions reportedly committed by the specific radio stations?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Hon Minister?

4.48 p.m.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, I can provide the House with specifics.

So, Mr Speaker, in the case of Fire Group of Companies Limited, they were granted the authorisation to operate a commercial FM station in Sunyani on 6th January, 2020, this expired on the 5th January, 2025. Fire Group of Companies Limited was required per Regulation 56(1) of the Electronic Communications Regulations 2011 (L. I. 1991) and condition 4 of their authorisation to submit a complete application, at least, three months prior to the expiration of their authorisation to renew the said authorisation.

Mr Speaker, the NCA notified Fire Group of Companies Limited in a letter dated 16th December, 2024 to submit a complete application to renew its authorisation by 5th January, 2025. Fire Group of Companies Limited, however, failed to submit the renewal. Following the expiration of the authorisation of the company on 5th January, 2025, the NCA issued a letter dated 18th February, 2025, directing them to cease operation. Like I stated earlier, the station has subsequently submitted a new application and we are processing it, but even during the processing period, in the spirit of good faith, we have asked them to resume operations.

Two, is the case of ISA Consult Limited. They were granted authorisation to operate a commercial FM station in

Tamale on 19th November, 2018. Again, per Regulation 56(1) of the Electronic Communications Regulations 2011 (L. I. 1991) and condition 5 of their authorisation, they ought to have submitted a complete application three months prior to the expiration of their authorisation. ISA Consult Limited failed to do so. Following the expiration of the authorisation of the company on 18th November, 2023, the NCA issued a letter dated 12th February, 2024, directing ISA Consult Limited to cease and desist its operations. ISA Consult Limited applied for a new authorisation in Tamale on 21st August, 2024.

They were issued a provisional authorisation on 13th November, 2024, and were asked to settle the provisional authorisation fee of GH¢61,985 by 12th January, 2025. They failed to pay the authorisation fee leading to the suspension of the authorisation. They have since made payments and we have, once again, given them permission to go back on air.

Three, is the Abochanel Media Group Limited. They got their authorisation to operate on 105.7 at Adidome in the Volta Region on 20th July, 2010. It expired on 19th July, 2015. Again, on 12th July, 2015, they were asked by the NCA to submit an application to renew by 10th August, 2015. Abochanel Media Group Limited submitted the renewal on 4th November, 2015. The company was given a provisional licence on 8th August, 2016. They paid the authorisation fee on 29th March, 2017.

Mr Speaker, that authorisation expired on 6th March, 2023. Abochanel Media Group Limited submitted an incomplete renewal application on 15th March, 2023. The NCA requested Abochanel Media Group Limited to submit their Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT) clearance, tax clearance, audited financial statements and NCA form AP01B by 10th June, 2023. Abochanel Media Group Limited informed the NCA on 6th November, 2023 that due to the nature of their business being not-for-profit, they should be exempted from submitting an audited financial statement, SSNIT and tax clearance certificate.

However, the legal division of the NCA on 23rd February, 2024 recommended that the request for waiver by Abochanel Media Group Limited should be denied and the company should be requested to submit same. The NCA communicated same to Abochanel Media Group Limited on 12th March, 2024.

Mr Speaker, as Minister, given the failure to submit all of these documents since 2023 and despite the refusal of the waiver by the NCA in 2024, we took the policy decision to suspend their operations. Abochanel Media Group Limited, in a letter dated 10th March, 2025, requested another waiver of the same tax clearance and Tax Identification Number (TIN) from the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA). We declined. They have hitherto submitted those documents and we have allowed them to go back on air.

Four, is the Okyeame Radio, also in similar situations. It is all about the request to submit the documents and reapply but they failed to do so. So, Mr Speaker, if I have leave of the questioner, it is the same scenario across all the other six and we have since allowed them, once they have complied with the law, to go back on air.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, Mr Speaker. May I find out from the Minister if there are plans to engage the National Media Commission in a bid to encourage compliance and to also respect the relevant laws. I am sure he will be happy to see the stations complying with the provisions of the law and I am wondering what collaborative effort he wishes to engage the Media Commission in this regard or context.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, I want to commend the questioner for this question, because it is critical that we make this point clear as the country listens to Parliament. When it comes to the renewal of a frequency authorisation and especially, because we have Members of Parliament who own radio stations, please, take note, the law is clear. One does not renew their radio licence when it expires. One must renew their radio licence at least 90 days before the expiration date. So, if one does not renew and we get into the 90 days to the

expiration, the licence cannot be renewed. It has to be a fresh authorisation.

This is the position of the law. Many media houses do not even renew in the 90 days, then they come post the expiration of their licences asking for renewals. They can only do a fresh application and when one does a fresh application, they will now have to go through the whole process of inspection, verification, provision licence authorisations and test transmission again. All of that must be done again.

So, our appeal to media houses is that we respect the freedom of expression, but as media practitioners, they have a responsibility to respect the law. We have engaged the Media Foundation for West Africa (MFWA). We have also engaged the Ghana Independent Broadcasters Association (GIBA) to draw their attention. In fact, what the NCA does is that it issues a notice to them six months to the expiration and that is three months before their window closes. The NCA writes to notify them but many times—Mr Speaker, if my memory serves me right, in the case of, for example, Wontumi Multimedia, which was part of a second batch of shutdowns we did, the NCA wrote to Wontumi Multimedia in 2022 and wrote back in 2023; so, it is on the back of these notices that we take enforcement action.

Once again, I think that it is a timely question and that the media houses should take advantage to bear in mind that 90 days to the expiration of their licence, they must indicate their willingness to renew and we will

continue to send the notices six months and three months to the time from the regulator.

I thank you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I find out from the Minister whether a spectrum allocation to these affected stations have been reallocated, and if it is the case, whether it went through due process.

4.58 p.m.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the directive that was given and enforced by the regulator in February was not a revocation of licences. In 2019, we had a revocation of licences, so we then had to reinstate those licences. What we authorised was a suspension.

A suspension means that the licence still holds, but you cannot operate on it and in the cases of the six and the subsequent 62 that we did, we have not revoked any licences. We only suspended the licences. When they rectified the infractions, we reinstated the licences. So, there was no process of going to the board or anything because there was no revocation and renewal of a fresh licence. This was just a reinstatement and a suspension, not a revocation. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you have the floor.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I find out from the Minister if there are plans or some strategic measures to draw a balance between regulatory

compliance and protection of media plurality? I do not know if he gets the sense of my question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, that is a fine line that as policy maker I must tow. A full respect for Article 162 of the Constitution on media freedom, but also ensuring that the corporate responsibilities of media practitioners must also be respected.

Mr Speaker, we will continue to tow the fine line between respecting the freedom of expression and media plurality, but also ensuring that the right things per the law—Mr Speaker, I think that it would be, for want of a better word, irresponsible on my part as Minister to say that because I want to respect media plurality, a media house should not pay their taxes. Because when we demand that they submit their tax clearance, it is to ensure that they are paying their tax obligations to the state. So, media houses have a responsibility to comply with the law. So, we will continue to respect the freedom of the media and media plurality but we will continue to engage through Ghana Independent Broadcasting Association (GIBA), Media Foundation for West Africa (MFWA), and our administrative processes as the regulator to ensure compliance with the law of the land. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I appreciate the detailed answers provided, but this may be my final question in respect of Order 89(3).

Mr Speaker, I appreciate the solutions and the answers, but does the Minister have an over-arching redress mechanism to deal with the challenge, especially the affected stations? Yes, I have heard him mention in part. For instance, the earlier notifications that were given, they are all part of that, but these measures exist in part. Are there any more redress mechanisms to provide solutions to the affected?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, when it comes to redress on the part of the media houses, and if that is the question, if media houses are unhappy about a decision taken by the regulator, they can appeal to the Ministry. Where the Ministry sides with the regulator, they can actually go to the Electronic Communications Tribunal. We saw that happen in 2019 when there was a closure of 137 media houses. It went to the Electronic Communications Tribunal, and the Justice Dartey-Baah Commission upheld the decision by the then Minister to shut down the radio stations, but then said that the fines that were imposed were illegal. He reinforced the position that 90 days to the expiration, if one fails to register, their licence had elapsed. The redress process is to go to the regulator and try to fix it with the regulator. Like in the case of *Agoo Channel*, they ask for a waiver. If they are unhappy with that, they come to the Ministry. If they are unhappy with the Ministry, that is why we have the Electronic Communications Tribunal which is the final arbiter relative to spectrum issues.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Jerry Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for indulging me. The Hon Minister indicated that one of the stations had to be closed because of security concerns, and that he was advised by the National Security. Is that *Gumah FM* and what has been the recent development with reference to consideration of reopening same?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the case of *Gumah FM* is a very particular one because *Gumah FM* and a number of other radio stations were shut down in 2023, if my memory serves me right, because of the role they were playing in incitement in the conflict in Bawku. In that instance, four media houses were shut down. After about six months of shutdown, the media houses signed a bond “of good behaviour” with the National Communication Authority (NCA) in late 2023, upon which they were reinstated.

In the current case where the directive was given to the NCA to shut down the radio station, I first got a request from the security apparatus to shut down. I declined that request and requested that there is a District Security Council (DISEC) in the constituency or the district and there is a Regional Coordinating Council. I requested that the Regional Coordinating Council must have a meeting with DISEC and take a decision on the complaints that had come

to the Ministry on insightful comments, not this time against ethnic behaviour, but against officers of the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ghana Police Service who were carrying out peacekeeping duties there. So, the incitement that came to our notice this time was against the security operatives so Regional Security (REGSEC) met and took a decision. I demanded the minutes of the REGSEC meeting and that was sent to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs and they forwarded that to the Ministry of the Interior which acts as the supervisory ministry for National Security. The Minister responsible for National Security made a request on the back of that, so we exercised extreme caution in taking this decision. At the moment, I am still following the briefing from National Security on the volatility of the situation there. If we are given the clearance that the situation has improved, we will reconsider it. However, let me state that that radio station is currently operating on Facebook.

They still carry out their broadcast on Facebook, not on the spectrum, and we keep getting reports from REGSEC and National Security, which I refer to another agency under my Ministry, the Cyber Security Authority. Because in some of the instances, specific people that we have identified, are calling for the attack on the Ghana Armed Forces.

Mr Speaker, so it is a very dicey situation, and I want to use this medium to plead with everyone who does radio broadcast. We have only one nation. The attack on our men in uniform; military or

police, cannot be countenanced by anyone. That a media house will be calling for attacks on them, irrespective of which side of the ethnic divide they sit on, our men in uniform must be protected at all times. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Alhaji Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Have you now moved back?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, my Colleague Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, the Second Deputy Minority Whip, was having a conversation with our boss that is why I was—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You have the floor.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister the reasons for closing those four radio stations on National Security grounds or briefings. Has he gone beyond the security briefings to engage the owners and if that was done, what measures is he putting in place so that sooner or later they can reopen those radio stations?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

5.08 p.m.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, as Minister, I have not authorised the shutdown of four radio stations. I have authorised the shutdown of one. In 2023, I was not a Minister, but that was when

there was the decision to shut down the four radio stations.

I am not privy to the reasons that were given to the then Minister to warrant the shutdown in 2023 of the four radio stations. However, what I am privy to is the fact that the four radio stations signed a bond of good behaviour, which I have records of at the National Communications Authority (NCA). I cannot speak to what the national security considerations were then but since I became the Minister, we have had to shut down only one, given the national security implications of the commentary on that radio station.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I know you miss me; I know.

But Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Minister for the answers he has given to this House. However, there seems to be a growing interference in the work of the NCA. We know that the Minister is supposed to give policy directions to the NCA and all of that, but even in the workings of the NCA, there seems to be a lot of ministerial interference, which is affecting the independence of the NCA. Because section 3(4) of the National Communication Act, clearly states that the Minister shall not interfere with the day-to-day administration of the Authority —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are violating Standing Order 88(7).

Mr D. A. Opoku: Mr Speaker, to ask my question, I would want to find out from the Minister why the excessive interference of his office to the NCA, and if he does not appreciate the fact that it is affecting the independence of the regulatory body.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, is your question emanating from the Question numbered 6(a)?

Mr D. A. Opoku: Yes, Mr Speaker, it has to do with the issuance of letters from the Minister's office, even revoking licences of radio stations.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let us look at the Question together: "To ask the Minister for Communications, Digital Technology and Innovations, the circumstances that necessitated the closure of the following radio stations." This has completely nothing to do with interference. So, I would advise you to file a fresh question.

Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Charles Asuako Owiredù: Mr Speaker, recognising the role played by the community radio stations, does the Hon Minister not think that the decision

to shut down these radio stations is a bit far-fetched?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, in fact, given the critical nature of community radio stations, they have a higher duty of responsibility to obey and respect the law. In the same way, Members of Parliament are expected to be of good behaviour because we are called Honourable; we are expected to do better than the regular citizen. It is the same way when you have a frequency to broadcast information and shape the minds and inform the people, you must abide by the law. Nobody is above the law; the law is the law.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Owiredù: Mr Speaker, are there plans to allocate more spectrums this year?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the question is on closure.

Mr Owiredù: Yes, so I am talking about community radio stations.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the question that brought the Minister to the House is on the closure of some radio stations. So, if you want to know from the Minister, the plans to open new radio stations, kindly file a fresh question.

Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister, clearly from his answers, he has demonstrated that he is expecting strict adherence from these community radio stations when it comes to the renewal of licenses. He has also indicated that notice is given six months prior to renewal and then one is actually supposed to renew it or submits one's applications for renewal three months before the expiration. Is it a position that once one submits their application, one is excluded from the possibility of their radio station being closed down? This is so that it will be clear for these community radio stations to know that once they submit their applications, they are free and that will take away the potential or the possibility of being closed down?

And I also want to find out from the Minister if there is some sort of assurance in there.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, applications can either be accepted or declined. And so, the fact that one applies for a renewal does not mean an automatic renewal because when one is applying, one applies with a certain number of documents. For example, one applies with their tax clearance certificate; one applies to show that they have been paying their taxes. One applies with an audited Financial Statement. So,

the application without the complete set of documents in itself makes one's application ineffective.

However, once one has begun the process before the 90 days, and if the Hon Member followed my response, for example, with the Abo Channel Media Group, they began within the 90 days but were unable to submit all the documentation. They came back to ask the NCA for a waiver, which the NCA declined. If they had met all the documentation within the period, we would not have shut them down because even when the waiver was requested and it was declined by the NCA, the NCA gave them a time frame to submit the required documents. So when one submits the documents before the 90 days, it gives one the opportunity to start the process, but one must make sure one submits completed documentation. What I must be clear about is that the regulator will not allow anybody to abuse the system of renewal, such that one just puts in an incomplete application to hold the hand of the regulator and continue broadcasting when their documentation is not complete. If one applies for renewal, we will check the documents and if they are up to date, we will renew it. If they are not complete, they will be given a timeline to submit their completed documents.

Thank you.

Mr Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, just a follow-up question.

By the Minister's answer, is there a specified period in law that is required of the NCA to consider one's application

when it is submitted to them? Do they have a specified period or is it open-ended or do they have the luxury of time to consider the application?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your question is, if the application is submitted, is there a time period within which the NCA is supposed to look at the application?

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, 90 days. That is why they are asked to apply at least 90 days before the expiration, so that at the time the licence is expiring, the NCA would have completed its processes and renewed the licence. They should not forget that the fact that they operate even one day without a valid licence is a breach of the law and a typical example of that is Asaase Radio, which operated for a period of about 10 weeks in 2024 after their licence had expired and only did an application 10 weeks later. It means in those 10 weeks, they were operating illegally without a licence.

So 90 days is the period one applies, we renew, and then we have a transition. Thank you.

5.18 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, may we move to another Urgent Question also standing in the name of Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, Member of Parliament for Effutu.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you equally have the authority?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, I do.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will permit you to ask the Question.

Immediate Cybersecurity Measures Implemented Following the Hacking of the President's X Account

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh on behalf of (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin) (NPP—Effutu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the immediate cybersecurity measures being implemented on digital platforms following the hacking of President Mahama's X account on 18th March, 2025.

Mr George: On 16th March 2025, the X account of President John Dramani Mahama was used to publish promotional content for a fraudulent Solana-based cryptocurrency, Solana Africa. The published tweets falsely implied the President's endorsement of a Memecoin (meme) token investment opportunity.

Our investigations at the Cyber Security Authority strongly indicate that the breach resulted from a social engineering attack targeting a public relations handler responsible for managing the President's account. Rather than direct account compromise, attackers exploited human vulnerabilities, tricking the handler into revealing access credentials, authorising malicious access

through a phishing link. This incident illustrates how human vulnerabilities, not just technical gaps, can expose high-value digital assets.

The attackers behind this event leveraged social engineering and not brute force tactics to weaponise the President's brand and influence. The Cyber Security Authority (CSA), as part of the National Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT) Enhancement Project and financed through the World Bank's Ghana Digital Acceleration Project, has acquired a Threat Intelligence and Digital Risk Management tool. This tool, when loaded with the profiles of approved Government officials, will automate the current manual process of trying to detect and respond to malicious activities involving the accounts of these officials.

Mr Speaker, at this point, let me segue and repeat that I have made an application to both Sides of the House since I became Minister, it has been five months, requesting that Leadership of both Sides of the House furnish the Ministry with the official social media handles of Members of Parliament, so that the Cyber Security Authority could work with platform operators to protect their accounts and take out fraudulent accounts. I am yet to receive one response from both Sides of the House.

The CSA has also engaged Meta, owners of *Facebook*, *Instagram*, and *WhatsApp*, to organise virtual sessions for account managers, for Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs), and very important persons (VIPs), like MPs, on how to properly set

up and manage their social media accounts.

Mr Speaker, the CSA has also planned to organise a cyber hygiene training for Government officials to sensitise appointees on the threats, risks, and measures to mitigate these threats to safeguard sensitive personal and Government data, as well as other digital assets. The Ministry, through the CSA, is committed to ensuring a secure, robust, and reliable network connectivity to all citizens, and will work closely with both local and international partners to achieve this.

Mr Speaker, if I may, there is another Question on the Order Paper for today that asks the same thing. I do not know if this Answer, given your discretion — it stands in the name of the Hon Member of Parliament for Effia Constituency, Mr Isaac Boamah Nyarko — would also apply to that Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If your Answer would take care of that particular Question, when we get there, then you say that your previous Answer has taken care of this.

Yes, a supplementary question?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Thank you. Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, I just want to plead with you—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us exhaust the supplementary question from the Question on the floor.

Mr Acheampong: I want to make an intervention before he comes in. The Minister has five other Questions to

answer. So, I just want to plead with you, if you could limit the supplementary questions to one per person, looking at the time. I am just pleading with you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Poku-Adusei: *Wo pɛ no ntem akɔ hene?*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please, these are issues to be resolved between Leadership. You do not put on your microphone to say “*wo pɛ no ntem akɔ hene?*”.

Mr Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, honestly, it was an accident.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if you would indulge me, my good Friend, the Minister, was expected to answer the Question, but he made some passing comments which I find quite interesting. As the Whip of my Side, I have not received an official communication to that effect, so if he would reach out to us officially, we would be glad to respond to him duly, in respect of getting an official social media account of Members. Mr Speaker, this is just for the records.

Now, my question will be, were there incidental vulnerabilities that were discovered, in respect of the President's X account? If there were any, has he resolved it permanently, or is it a work in progress?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, all vulnerabilities related to the President's X account have been dealt with decisively, between the CSA, the handlers of his account, and the operators of the X platform. No further vulnerabilities exist.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I further wish to know from the Minister, if the hacking went beyond the President's X account and got into the general digital infrastructure of the country? If that was the case, can he confirm or deny?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, there is absolutely no indication of any compromise of our digital infrastructure as a country. It remains as robust as it has always been. When it came to the President's account, within 26 hours, we were able to work with the platform operators to recover full control of the account. Thank you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I would not seek the opinion of the Minister, because that offends our Rules. On the 26 hours, I put it to the Minister that, for a whole Ministry to use 26 hours to secure or contain—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then, in that case, you are violating Standing Order 88.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, would you listen to me?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, it is the way you have started. You asked

me whether that would offend the Rules or not. Let me provide a guideline, based on which you can proceed. Order 88 (7) reads:

“A Member, in asking a Question, shall not

- (a) address the House;
- (b) raise any argument; or
- (c) offer an opinion.”

So, you may proceed to ask the question, being guided by Order 88 (7).

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Minister says his outfit used 26 hours in containing the situation. Does he appreciate these number of hours as excessive, in terms of the fact that it had to do with the First Gentleman of the land? Is it appreciated as excessive hours used in containing the situation?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister?

5.28 p.m.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the platforms are not owned and managed locally.

Mr Speaker, the platforms are not owned and managed locally. They are not owned by Ghana. X is owned by its majority shareholder, Elon Musk. Mr Speaker, my Answer was that it took us 26 hours to get full control of the account, but within three hours, we had reached out to our point of contact in X and X had immediately taken control of

the account. However, the standard operating procedure is that they will do an analysis of the breach to determine whether it was a social engineering attack or a system vulnerability.

Now, that is the preserve of the platform operator, so they had to do their work and analysis and because of the individual involved, the first gentleman of the land, we involved law enforcement agencies, both here in Ghana and in the United States of America (USA); so, the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) also got involved in the case. All of that had to be cleared before full control was reissued to Ghana or to the handlers of the President.

It is not that for 26 hours, there was no control, but that is the time it took for the platform operators to finish their own threat analysis and restore control. This is something anybody who has used *Facebook*, which is another platform—When one makes a complaint on their account, at times, it takes about 48 hours for them to do their own analysis and get back to the person. That is outside of our control.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, supplementary question number five.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, I am still within the provisions of Order 89(3).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you should ask five.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, can the Minister confirm, as an afterthought, that measures have been

put in place to forestall the reoccurrence of such incidents, not just for the President, but generally.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: An afterthought of? Let me get your question clear.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, as an aftermath of what happened, has he considered measures to forestall the reoccurrence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right. The word is “aftermath”.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, yes, we have taken adequate measure to ensure that the handlers of the accounts of the President and by extension, all government officials, and if we work with Parliament, all public officers of Parliament, will have their accounts protected. I stated that we had just secured a threat intelligence tool under the Ghana Digital Acceleration Programme (GDAP) to boost our capabilities as a country handling such occurrences. So, yes, we have taken adequate measure post the event.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku: Mr Speaker, I appreciate the efforts by the cyber security unit of Ghana to retrieve the account of H. E. the President of the Republic of Ghana. Just to say that the account was hacked in March, so March, April, May, June, and the Minister has assured us that they have taken adequate measures to prevent further hacking of

the account of the President. But is the Minister aware that *X* provides a special verification for persons like the President? There is a grey verification. As we speak, since the day the account of the President was hacked, the President still has a blue verification which means that somebody just paid for it and—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is your question?

Mr Ansah: Mr Speaker, my question is that what steps has the Minister taken to get the President a grey verification, the very thing that he intends to do for Members of Parliament?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, let us be clear. There is no difference in the security architecture for blue ticks or grey ticks. There is no difference. When we look at the security measures for blue-ticked accounts, grey-ticked accounts and yellow-ticked accounts, it is the same level of security architecture that *X* provides to all of those verifications. All the colour coding does is to identify one as a public officer, one as a corporate institution and one as a politically exposed person. It is the decision of the handlers of the President, at this point in time, to maintain the blue tick, but that in no way compromises the security architecture around it.

Let me reiterate the fact that the Cyber Security Authority (CSA) is on top of its brief relative to the social media handles of the President.

Mr Charles Asuako Owiredu: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the

Minister if H. E. the President manages the accounts himself.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, my understanding is that that is a matter of national security; so, I am unable to answer.

Mr Owiredu — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let me read the relevant rules:

“Any other Member may be allowed to ask not more than two supplementary questions”.

So, you “may” be allowed; it is not an automatic right. We feel, “I am entitled to”; it is not your entitlement. You may be allowed, so that is up to the discretion of the Speaker.

Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 6(c) which stands in the name of Hon Patricia Appiagyei, Member of Parliament for Asokwa.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, fortified by Order 88(3), respectfully, if I have your leave to ask the Questions on behalf of the Member because she has directed—I have the authority—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, Order 88(3) cannot fortify you. If you have the authority, say so.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I have the authority and I ask permission to ask—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Based on the authority, permission is granted.

Mr Shaib: Very well, Mr Speaker.

Completion and Operationalisation of the Digital Youth Village

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib *on behalf of Ms Patricia Appiagyei (NPP — Asokwa)*: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the projected timeline for the completion and full operationalisation of the Digital Youth Village (DYV) project at the University of Ghana, which is currently at 70 per cent completion.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the Digital Youth Village (DYV) is a centre of excellence for digital entrepreneurship and youth skill development. This centre will connect policy, academia and industry through hands-on training and business incubation, creating an environment where Ghanaian youth can thrive in the digital economy. The DYV will operate through five thematic and specialised hubs, each addressing a critical sector of digital transformation as outlined in the digital economy policy: agri-tech, health tech, edu-tech, e-commerce, and FinTech.

The expected completion time for physical construction is September 2025. The expected time for operationalisation is October 2025. The Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations has requested for and is awaiting commitment authorisation from the Ministry of Finance to pay outstanding Interim Payment Certificates (IPCs) submitted by the consultant.

Government is currently auditing the project as part of the audit of projects from the previous Government. This has

affected IPC 6, 7 and 8. IPC 9 and 10 have also since been submitted by the consultant for processing. Once these IPCs are paid, the contractor can complete the work as scheduled by September 2025.

The Ministry is hopeful that operationalisation can commence within the new academic year. As part of the Budget approved by this House, an amount in excess of GH¢80 million has been approved for the completion of this project.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I want to be clear. Is the Hon Minister saying that we would have to make payments of the IPCs raised before there will be full commitment towards the completion of the project? He indicated that there are some IPCs which have been raised and I am asking if we need those IPCs to be paid. Are they supposed to be paid before we would have a completion of this project?

5.38 p.m.

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the IPCs are basically the certificates for work done, so the contractor has done that work and we need to pay him so that he can complete the remaining 30 per cent. The money and funds are available but the new regime at the Ministry of Finance is that one cannot commit any resource without a commencement warrant signed by the Minister for

Finance. That commencement warrant request has gone from the Ministry because we have certified the IPCs 6 to 10.

However, the Ministry of Finance is auditing all projects that were ongoing under the previous administration and that is what has held the commencement warrant from being issued. Once it is issued, the Ministry will be able to write to the Controller to pay those IPCs and then we will get the project back on track. Our understanding is that before the middle of July, the audit would have been completed, we would have gotten our commencement warrant and that is why we have the September and October timelines to complete the project. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Shaib: That is so. Hon Minister, in case we are not able to have the commitment warrants fully issued, do we have any alternatives in ensuring that this project will still go on and get completed as you indicated that it should be ready by the next academic year?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the Ministry is confident, given our engagements with the Ministry of Finance that we will be given the commitment authorisation anytime soon and that this will complete—But let me be clear that the Digital Youth Village is not to be used for academic work of the University. It is going to be a centre of

excellence owned by the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations because it is coming out of our budget. But academic support will come from the University for the various trainings we want to use because the Digital Youth Village (DYV) is going to be one of our centres of excellence for the One Million Coders programme and some of our faculty will come from the University. So, it has no bearing on the University's academic work because those are centres of excellence in the five tech areas; FinTech, EduTech, HealthTech, AgriTech and E-Commerce. Thank you.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Hon Minister for indulging me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 6(d) standing in the name of Nana Ampaw Kwame Addo-Frempong.

Circumstances Surrounding Dismissal of Five Zonal Managers

Nana Ampaw Kwame Addo-Frempong (NPP — Abuakwa North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovation the circumstances surrounding the sudden dismissal of five (5) zonal managers of the National Communications Authority in Koforidua, Ho, Takoradi, Bolgatanga and Tamale Zonal officers.

Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations (Mr Samuel Nartey George) (MP): Mr Speaker, Section 19 of the National Communications Authority Act, 2008

(Act 769) says officers and staff of the NCA shall be appointed by the President in accordance with Article 195 of the Constitution. As Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations, acting on the authority of the President, I terminated the appointment of the five senior managers heading the NCA zonal officers in Koforidua, Ho, Takoradi, Bolgatanga and Tamale on 11th March, 2025.

The NCA has subsequently paid all the separation benefits to the former staff in line with the NCA's HR Policy Manual 2017. Mr Speaker, the five staff, after collecting their separation benefits, have now gone to sue the NCA in court. Because the matter is before court, I shall refrain from any further comments on the matter. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Mr Addo-Frempong: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity again—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, in view of the fact that the Minister indicated the matter is in court, therefore he will not comment on it, do you want to proceed to ask any further question?

Mr Addo-Frempong: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku: Mr Speaker, my question has nothing to do with the matter before court. I just need confirmation from the Hon Minister. Is it the President that asked him to dismiss

the five zonal managers? That is all. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, when the President swore me into office, I took three oaths. The oath of secrecy, the oath of allegiance, and the oath of a Minister of State. Communication between the President and myself is bound by the oath of secrecy. Thank you.

Mr Opoku: Mr Speaker, this is a House of records—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please—

Mr Opoku: Sorry, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You have no opportunity of asking another supplementary question. So, let me give the floor to Hon Baafi?

Mr Michael Baafi Okyere: Thank you, Mr Speaker. This is a House of records, the Parliament of Ghana. I think we have a responsibility towards our constituents and Ghanaians in general. We want the Minister, with your leave, to answer the specific question. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, in view of the fact that I understand what a classified information is, I am unable to grant the leave.

Mr Okyere: Mr Speaker, can I please ask another question, please?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, you are entitled to one supplementary question.

Mr Okyere: No, let me just ask one, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: One supplementary question, please. Let us move to item numbered 6(e) standing in the name of Mr Charles Asuako Owiredo, Member of Parliament for Abirem.

Details of agreement with Rektron Group for the acquisition of 60 per cent stake in AT Ghana

Mr Charles Asuako Owiredo (NPP — Abirem): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations to provide details on the terms of the agreement with Canada-based Rektron Group for the acquisition of a 60 per cent stake in AT Ghana including the financial valuation, safeguards for national interests and measures to ensure the deal enhances telecommunications infrastructure and affordability for Ghanaians. Thank you.

Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovation (Mr Samuel Nartey George) (MP): Mr Speaker, as Parliament may recall, the Government of Ghana in 2021 acquired 100 per cent shareholding in the joint venture vehicle called AT Ghana. In acquiring the company, the Akufo-Addo led government accepted liability in excess of US\$200 million. This debt has negatively impacted operations and viability of AT Ghana and inhibited growth of any kind.

Since the assumption of office as Minister in February this year, I have set out to meet the creditors of AT Ghana to restructure the debt portfolio and determine the future of the company. My office has received a number of proposals and has studied same. In May this year, the Ministry signed an MoU with Messrs Afritel Rektron to explore the possibility of a partnership arrangement for the management of the company. At the moment, Mr Speaker, the Ministry has not entered into any agreement with Canada-based Rektron Group. So, in direct response to the question, I am unable to provide any details as there is no agreement to provide details on. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary question?

Mr Owiredo: Mr Minister, per the MoU that you signed with Rektron, can you tell us if the company, Rektron, has any track record in the communication space? Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, as this is an ongoing engagement between the representatives of the Ministry, Messrs KPMG, and Afritel Rektron, and again, it is not Rektron. There is Rektron as a company, but the consortium that is dealing with the Ministry on an MoU is called Afritel Rektron. I am unable to go into the specifics or pass judgement on the capabilities of a partner we are in conversation with. That will be acting in bad faith.

5.48 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Owiredu: Mr Speaker, in the Minister's earlier Answer he did say that AT is indebted to the tune of about US\$200 million. Are we sure that with their coming in, if the final agreement is signed with this company, this company will be able to invest in AT in such a way that AT can stand on its feet and then match companies like the MTN?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, the challenging situation of AT is testament to the poor governance that we saw in the sector for eight years. The fact that two viable thriving companies that were handed over to the NPP Administration after eight years were brought to their knees with US\$200 million of debts. I can assure you that any decision that I take as Minister will be in the best interest of the company and the Ghanaian taxpayer.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Owiredu: Mr Speaker, the Minister, in his earlier answer also said that this new company that he has signed an MoU with is Afritel Rektron. Does this company, Afritel Rektron, has any track record in Ghana in the communication space?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr George: Mr Speaker, I wish to seek clarity from you. I was asked to come and answer a Question on what the details of a 60 per cent agreement were. Now, I am being asked to speak about a partner in that agreement and pass judgement on them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you introduced the Afritel Rektron, so the question is based on what you have introduced. If you do not have the answer available, you can say so.

Mr George: No, Mr Speaker, I introduced Afritel Rektron as the entity we have signed an MoU with, which is the question I was asked. Yes, so we have signed an MoU with Afritel Rektron. I believe that their track record is an issue of public knowledge and can be verified from the Office of Registrar of Companies.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. If that is your answer, we will take it to be your answer.

Hon Members, let us move to regular Questions. The item numbered seven, Question number 142, standing in the name of Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, MP for Effia.

Yes, you have the Floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF COMMUNICATION, DIGITAL TECHNOLOGY AND INNOVATIONS

Circumstances that Led to the Hacking of the Account of the President of Ghana

Mr Frederick Addy *on behalf of Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia)*: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I come under Order 88(3). I have the authority by the Hon Member. I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovation, the circumstances that led to the hacking of the accounts of the President of Ghana and what efforts have been made to avoid its future occurrence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I think the Answer to this Question is similar to the previous Answer provided. So, do we still take the Answer? Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, interpretation of the rules in this House is in your bosom, but if I may do a reasonable deduction.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: My Question was an Urgent Question and hence, by practice, the Answers would not be published in the Order Paper.

However, his Question is different. His Question is a normal Question, so to speak. However, since the content is the same, Mr Speaker, may you direct that the Answers should be probably given to

the Member so that he can appreciate, because he read it as an Urgent Question and the Answers were not provided in the Order Paper.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, and he indicated that in view of the fact that the Answers that he is providing will be the same Answer to Question numbered 142, should he take the two together? Then I indicated to the Minister that when we get there, we would address the issue. So, it has already gone into the record that the Answers which are being provided to the Question that you asked would as well answer Question numbered 142.

Can we make progress?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Certainly, yes, Mr Speaker, we should make progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the Question numbered 238, standing in the name of Hon Peter Lanchene Toobu, Member of Parliament for Wa West.

Yes, Hon James Agalga?

Mr James Agalga: Mr Speaker, with your leave, may I ask the Question on behalf of the Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu. He has instructed me to do so on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, we do not base it on instruction and I cannot grant my leave based on instructions.

Mr Agalga: Authority.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Agalga: I am guided, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you have his authority, permission is granted.

When will the over 50 Communities have Network.

Mr James Agalga on behalf of Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu (NDC — Wa West): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations when the over 50 communities, which include the following, will have network connectivity. (i) Dabo (ii) Gurungu (iii) Kuukyileyiri (iv) Vieri (v) Lassie.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Samuel Nartey George: Mr Speaker, even before I answer, I want to crave the indulgence of the constituents of Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu to forgive any possible butchering of the pronunciation of the community names. But the Ghana Investment Fund for Electronic Communication (GIFEC) has completed the construction of nine sites in Kekelepare, Sanouri, Bankpama, Donye, Jaglu, Nerekuten, Lassia-Tuolu, Benrinyasi, and Wechiau Bau. These sites are currently on air and the communities will have mobile network coverage when these sites are completed.

Mr Speaker, six other sites in Pongnyamayiri, Kekelepare, Dalinnyiri, Kandeu, Kuzie and Wuokoraa have been built, integrated and operationalised.

Mr Speaker, the details on the status of the five communities mentioned are as follows:

- i. Gurungu and Kuukyileyiri: These sites have been constructed, integrated and pending operationalisation.
- ii. Lassie: There is no record on Lassie now. A site has however been constructed at Lassie-Toulu which is on air.
- iii. Vieri: This Site has been surveyed and acquired for construction. Materials for the construction are ready and will be moved to the site for construction work to begin.
- iv. Dabo: This community has not yet been captured by GIFEC.

Mr Speaker, a drive test exercise will be arranged to capture this community and many other communities in the district for simulation and subsequent planning and deployment. GIFEC is currently working with the contractor and its sub-contractors to ensure all Sites are completed and operationalised by the end of the year, 2025.

GIFEC remains committed to improving communication infrastructure in the Wa West District and the country at large.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, on behalf of the people of Wa West, I would like to thank the Hon Minister for the efforts he is making towards ensuring that the communities listed get connectivity. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members Question time has ended.

5.58 p.m.

On behalf of the House, I express our sincere gratitude to the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations. Hon Minister, thank you very much for attending upon the House to answer Questions. You are hereby discharged.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, we would take the item numbered 11, a procedural Motion. After that, the Speaker would indulge us to take a commemorative Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, he should start with a procedural Motion, then take the substantive Motion before we go to the Statement. The procedural Motion will just pave the way for the substantive Motion. We do not have to do the procedural Motion and go back to the Statement, then come back to the substantive Motion.

Mr Speaker, does the Majority Leader not want Government Business to be done? Is it the case that the Majority Leader is stalling Government Business?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the item numbered 12 is consequent upon 11, so once 11 is taken, it is a matter of course. We would take the item numbered 12.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, he made an earlier application that he would rather prefer the—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am clear in my mind what he is talking about.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, would you not listen to me? I am your Friend.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I know you are my very good Friend.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, his application was that we should take the procedural Motion, when it is done, then we go and take Statement before we come to the substantive Motion. What is that? And I am questioning whether —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I did not get it that way. We would have to exhaust items 11 and 12, then we come to the Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, can you listen to me? Is it the case that the Majority Leader is sabotaging Government Business? Is that the case? *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Chairman has given clear indications that if he is allowed to take all his Motions, he would leave the Chamber and then Government Business will stall. Government Business includes making important Statements, commemorative Statements, so we would do the procedural Motion, take the Statement, and then we would come back.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 11 on page 4 of today's Order Paper—Motion.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee.

MOTIONS

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025 may be moved today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion ably moved. Any seconder?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion numbered 12. Chairman of the Committee, you may move the Motion.

Report on the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025.

Mr Speaker, I present the Committee's Report, and I ask the Office of Chamber Reporting to capture the entire Report as having been read.

Introduction

The Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025, was laid by the Attorney-General and Minister of Justice, Hon Dr Dominic Akuritinga Ayine, on 28th March, 2025. The Instrument was laid in accordance with Article 11(7) of the Constitution and Order 100 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

In accordance with Order 220(3) of the Standing Orders, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Instrument to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation for consideration and report. The Committee met and deliberated on the referral and presents its Report to the House.

Deliberations

The Committee met on 28th March, 2025, and considered the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025. In attendance were the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, Hon Dr Dominic Akuritinga Ayine, the Registrar of Companies, Ms Maame Sammu Peprah, and her technical team, and officials from the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Minister, Registrar of Companies and the team of officials from the Offices of the Attorney-General's Department and Registrar of Companies for attending upon the Committee to assist with the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during its deliberations:

- a. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- b. The Standing Orders of Parliament of Ghana;
- c. The Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Act, 2020 (Act 1015);
- d. The Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025; and
- e. The Report of the Stakeholder Consultation Workshop on the Draft Corporate Insolvency Restructuring Regulations.

The Scope of the Committee's Mandate

The Committee was guided by the provisions of Article 11 (7) of the 1992 Constitution and Standing Order 220 (4) in considering the referral. These provisions enjoin the Committee to determine whether a Regulation under consideration:

- a. is in accordance with the Constitution or the Act under which it is made;
- b. contains any matter which should more appropriately be dealt with in an Act of Parliament;
- c. contains imposition of any tax;
- d. directly or indirectly bars the jurisdiction of the courts;
- e. gives retrospective effect to any of the provisions in respect of which the Constitution or the Act does not expressly give that power;
- f. involves expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or public revenues;
- g. appears to make an unusual or unexpected use of powers conferred by the Constitution or the Act pursuant to which the Regulations were made;
- h. appears to have been unjustifiably delayed in its publication or in laying it before Parliament; and
- i. for any reason, in its form or purpose, requires clarification.

Background

The Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025, are being enacted to support the effective implementation of the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Act, 2020 (Act 1015), together with the Companies

Act, 2019 (Act 992) and the Chartered Institute of Restructuring and Insolvency Practitioners Act, 2024 (Act 1117).

Prior to the coming into force of the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Act, 2020 (Act 1015), which introduced a rescue-oriented framework into Ghana's insolvency regime, insolvency was addressed mainly through official liquidation proceedings under the repealed Companies Act, 1963 (Act 179). Under the previous regime, insolvency proceedings often led directly to the dissolution of distressed companies without exploring avenues for recovery or restructuring.

The promulgation of Act 1015 marked a paradigm shift by establishing procedures for administration and restructuring, allowing companies in financial distress to appoint insolvency practitioners with a mandate to help turn the business around. This form of bankruptcy protection enables businesses to reorganise and potentially return to viability rather than being prematurely liquidated.

The new Regulations are, therefore, a necessary adjunct to Act 1015. They provide detailed procedural guidance on matters expressly reserved for subsidiary legislation under the Act. These include the thresholds for determining insolvency, procedures for meetings of creditors and watershed meetings, and the appointment, resignation, removal, and replacement of insolvency practitioners. The Regulations also establish reporting obligations and address other matters essential to the

practical and effective enforcement of the provisions of the Act.

In effect, the Regulations and the parent Act represent a significant stride toward strengthening Ghana's corporate rescue culture and enhancing investor confidence in the business regulatory framework.

Purpose of the Legislative Instrument

Fundamentally, the draft Instrument aims to establish clear thresholds for determining a company's inability to pay its debts or fulfil other financial obligations. It also sets out the procedures for convening a meeting of creditors and a watershed meeting. Furthermore, it outlines the processes for the appointment, removal, resignation, and replacement of insolvency practitioners, prescribes the necessary reporting mechanisms, and addresses any additional matters required to ensure the effective implementation of the provisions of the parent Act.

Pre-Laying Consideration of the Instrument

In accordance with the established practice of the Committee to hold pre-laying sessions with Ministries, Departments, and Agencies (MDAs) for the review of draft Legislative Instruments, the Committee held a pre-laying session with the Registrar of Companies and her technical team to examine the proposed Instrument. This session afforded the Committee the opportunity to offer recommendations for amendments prior to the formal laying of the Instrument.

The engagement was especially important because pursuant to Article 11(7) of the Constitution, a Legislative Instrument cannot be modified once it has been laid before Parliament. The pre-laying session, therefore, provides a vital opportunity for the Committee to refine and modify the Instrument thereby ensuring consistency with stated objectives and compliance with legal standards and all relevant legal provisions.

Observations

In the course of its deliberations with the Attorney-General and officials from the Office of the Registrar of Companies, the Committee made the following observations:

Compliance with Constitutional and Legal Requirements

The Committee is satisfied that the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025, conforms with the 1992 Constitution and the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Act, 2020 (Act 1015). The Instrument does not impose any form of taxation, and does not oust the jurisdiction of the courts. It affirms the role of the judiciary in insolvency-related matters. Additionally, the Instrument does not apply retroactively. Also, the Instrument contains no provisions that authorise expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or other public resources. The Regulations is, therefore, compliant with laid-down laws and satisfies all the relevant procedural arrangements.

Establishment of the Insolvency Services Division

The Committee observed that the Regulations provide for the establishment of an Insolvency Services Division within the Office of the Registrar of Companies. This Division is intended to serve as a specialised technical arm responsible for overseeing insolvency-related matters and ensuring regulatory compliance by insolvency practitioners. The Division is mandated to collaborate with the Chartered Institute of Restructuring and Insolvency Practitioners (CIRIP) to support the training, licensing, and operational efficiency of practitioners. This initiative is a critical step toward strengthening institutional capacity and improving the quality and accountability of insolvency practice in the country.

Judicial Oversight and Restructuring Outcomes

The Committee further notes the role of the courts in facilitating and overseeing the corporate restructuring process as provided under the Act and the Regulations. In the case where restructuring efforts fail, the legal framework offers a structured transition into liquidation. This ensures a seamless progression from rescue to resolution, whether through administration or liquidation. The Regulations thus acknowledge both voluntary and court-supervised interventions, aligning with international best practices for corporate rescue and insolvency.

Legal Framework governing Private Liquidations

The Committee recognises the clear distinction made between private and formal liquidations within the Regulations. In situations where companies voluntarily elect to cease operations, often for strategic or special purpose, the Regulations allow for private liquidation, provided the company is solvent. However, where insolvency is discovered during the process, the company may transition into administration or formal liquidation. This flexible approach allows companies to responsibly exit the market while protecting creditor interests where necessary.

Ethical Standards and Oversight Functions

The Committee commends the inclusion of ethical standards and regulatory oversight provisions for insolvency practitioners. The Registrar of Companies, in collaboration with CIRIP, is empowered to ensure that practitioners operate with integrity and competence. A registry of licensed practitioners is maintained, alongside a framework for disciplinary actions, resignations, remuneration, and professional indemnity. These measures foster transparency, uphold standards of practice, and protect stakeholders throughout the insolvency process.

Procedural Clarity and Technical Framework

The Committee acknowledges the detailed procedural and technical framework provided by the Regulations.

Key provisions include the two tests for determining insolvency, the balance sheet test and the cash flow test as well as processes for creditor meetings, debt verification, liquidator duties, notice requirements, and the formation of creditor committees. The Regulations also outline the content and standards for various filings and reports, ensuring consistency and clarity in implementation. This comprehensive procedural guidance is essential for ensuring that the intent of the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Act, 2020, is realised in practice.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee acknowledges that the enactment of the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations is not only necessary, but long overdue. Since the passage of the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Act, 2020 (Act 1015), there have been several cases of liquidation and restructuring which were managed using practical measures in the absence of formal regulations. The Registrar of Companies, in collaboration with professional bodies such as CIRIP, has operated within the framework of the Act, however, the new Regulations will provide clear and consistent guidance for implementation, particularly, concerning thresholds for insolvency, the role of insolvency practitioners, and procedural safeguards.

In light of the above-mentioned, the Committee is satisfied that the Instrument meets the legal requirements as specified in relevant laws, and accordingly recommends to the House to

adopt its Report for the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025, to come into force in accordance with Article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution.

Respectfully submitted.

Question proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Motion moved, and Report presented. Any seconder?

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Report before the House. Mr Speaker, I would urge the Committee Members, especially—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Kindly second the Motion.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I second the Motion, and by so doing, I would want to contribute to the Report.

Mr Speaker, I just want to admonish the Chairman and Members of the Committee to go beyond presenting the Report to the House and find time to educate the public because we cannot just pass the law and leave the law on the shelves, and people may not take advantage of it.

We all know what happened in the financial sector. People go and invest in institutions and do not even know that they are winding up. They do not even know that they have liquidity issues. If they know and there is education, the companies themselves will file for insolvency. So, when they file for liquidation, people will get their

investment back. But they would not know and will sit there, and if there is a run on the institutions, at the end of the day, all their investments will go to waste. So, we cannot just pass the law and leave the law to just remain on the shelves. Let us also educate and help people. Although the Executive is there to do the implementation—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: First Deputy Majority Whip, I understand that there is a need to educate the general public on the laws passed. But is it the responsibility of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation to do so? Because you are urging the Chairman and the Committee to do that.

Mr Acheampong: The responsibility rests on all of us. But they can take the lead, so that we will help them execute that project. Because people will ask who passed the law. We passed the law. And they will say that they do not know the existence of the law that was passed. So, one cannot say that ignorance of the law is not an excuse. Let us help our people. That is what they have voted for. We are here to represent the people. Let us give them the right information so that they will benefit from the work we do here.

But we passed the law, and we are not giving true meaning to the law. At the end of the day, what have we done to ourselves? So let us also help the people because with what happened with Nana Appiah Mensah (NAM1), if he knew and the company was registered, he would have fought for liquidation and insolvency, and people would have got their investment. Now thousands of people have died because of

irresponsibility on the part of management— *[Interruption]*—Yes, Capital Bank and the rest. Because people do not know that if they put in the application, there will be some mitigating effect on them. If one travels outside the country, this is what people do.

6.08 p.m.

They change the names of companies, file for liquidation and insolvency and get the investments of people for them. Let them take advantage of the law, so that at the end of the day, they will say, Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah and Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah, incoming, were part of the Ninth Parliament that passed the law to safeguard our investment and our interest.

Mr Speaker, with these few remarks, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Question proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Education?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu (NDC — Tamale South): Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I noted the guidance from the Majority Leader, but I am commenting principally for three reasons, so that our new Members of Parliament can learn through your guide, what is called subsidiary legislation or what is called a regulation. Also, to thank the Chairman of the Committee, at least, for being proactive in reporting back to this House. Mr Speaker, in the past, we have had instances where Regulations are laid and the report is not even provided for the

House to, at least, have a bite and make consequential guidance.

As noted by the Chairman of the Committee, one of the principal responsibilities of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation, which has been satisfied in this instance, is whether the Regulation is consistent with the provisions of the parent Act and whether the Regulations and the parent Act respect the tenets of the provisions of the 1992 Constitution. I have noted that they have provided for all that.

Then, in particular, the purpose of the Regulation is carefully provided for under Regulations 1. For our learners, Article 11(7) of the Constitution—For those who have studied law, we describe it as the hierarchy of the laws in order of importance: the Constitution, Enactments, Orders, Rules and Regulations.

Mr Speaker, 11(7) says that,

“Any Order, Rule or Regulation made by a person or authority under a power conferred by this Constitution or any other law shall—

(a) be laid before Parliament.”

It has been laid and published in the *Gazette*. So, again, for our new Members of Parliament, normally when a Bill is introduced, we go to the back page to see whether it has been *gazetted* or not and it is for two important reasons. Yesterday, the Leadership debated it.

Even though this is a Regulation – so there is a difference between a Bill and a Regulation – it is whether a Bill, laid

before Parliament, satisfies the requirement of Article 106 of the Constitution. We take the Explanatory Memorandum and other issues for granted. Yesterday, the Leader tried to resolve it. What is important for Members of Parliament is that it shall not come into force, or at the expiration of the 21 Sitting days after being so laid, unless Parliament, by the expiration of the 21 days, annuls the order.

So, the only power we have here is that we can annul, but we can only annul with a vote of not less than two-thirds. So that, once it is laid, as Mr Speaker used to observe in his past life at the other Side, he was one of the expertise in this area, is whether there can be correction to a Regulation once it is laid before the House. We have been guided by the reference Mr Speaker has always made to the Supreme Court ruling on the matter.

Mr Speaker, finally, on the content itself, there are many companies in Ghana, even today, that are in distress and I hope that Colleagues will tolerate me. It is not to do politics. If a company in 2019 or 2021 went in to borrow US\$3 million at the exchange rate of GH¢6 to US\$1, which is GH¢18 million, by 2023 or 2024, the same GH¢18 million became GH¢36 million. Naturally, that company would be in distress and that company is likely to be cited for liquidation or insolvency. How is any company going to work and pay that? This provides an opportunity that, no, it is not the doing of the company. Therefore, the company should be given an opportunity in order to be able to have life.

Now, with this law, we are giving hope to many of those entities that no, they should undertake some restructuring and see whether they can – That is why the performance of Government has some significance on how the private sector and corporate entities survive and thrive.

Mr Speaker, with this comment, I thank you for the opportunity.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we will take the commemorative Statement on the World Drugs Day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, today, marks International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking. We have four Statements on the subject matter and I crave your indulgence to take the four Statements together, so that we can comment on it since they are all on the same subject matter.

Yes. Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I have no objection to the taking of the Statement. However, I wish to know the Members in whose names the Statements stand. This is because, ordinarily, we should have been aware, maybe, at Conclave, then we can get Members to contribute meaningfully to the Statements. This is coming as a surprise. I have no objection, but if I know the Members—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will go over it. One Statement stands in the name of Mr Godwin Animli Dorgbadzi-Dorani. This Statement was admitted on 23rd June, 2025. We also have a Statement which stands in the name of Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, Member of Parliament for Weija-Gbawe Constituency. His Statement was admitted on 11th June, 2025. Then we also have another Statement in the name of Mr Haruna Mohammed admitted on 23rd June, 2025. Then the last one is the by Hon Member for Binduri, Mr Mahmoud.

So, Hon Minority Chief Whip, these are the four Statements before me. I will then proceed to give the floor—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if you may, with your kind indulgence, if I may respectfully refer you to Order 93(8). With your leave, if I may read:

“The Clerk shall make available to Members, copies of admitted Statements.”

Mr Speaker, you had advised that we should all position ourselves to ensure that we enforce the provision of the Standing Orders. We are clearly in breach. Members do not have copies. I am not sure the Clerks-at-the-Table have copies.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if it is your decision—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, if you look at the Statements, I admit the

Statement transmitted through the Clerks-at-the-Table.

so I cannot hold brief for them.

6.18 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we should ensure that the provisions within the Standing Orders are enforced without adding more, I think we can proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, clerks, ensure you make enough copies of the Statement available for Members.

I will now proceed to give the floor to Mr Haruna Mohammed.

STATEMENT

World Drug Day

Mr Haruna Mohammed (NDC — Asunafo North): Thank you Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to address this august House.

Today, the 26th of June 2025, we join the global community in commemorating the International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking or the World Drug Day, designated by the United Nations General Assembly. In Ghana, this issue is particularly pressing, as the alarming rise in substance abuse among our youth demands immediate and decisive action.

Mr Speaker, the global drug crisis affects millions, with the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime reporting that nearly 200 million people use illicit drugs worldwide, including cannabis, cocaine,

opiates, and synthetic substances. Less than one-fifth of those affected receive adequate treatment. In Ghana, the situation is dire. According to a 2023 study by the Ghana Health Service and the Mental Health Authority, approximately 1.25 million Ghanaians grapple with drug-related issues, with marijuana, tramadol, codeine, and synthetic opioids being the most prevalent.

A 2024 study by the Department of Children, Ministry of Gender, Children, and Social Protection revealed that 7 per cent of adolescents aged between 10 and 17 reported lifetime alcohol use, with increasing experimentation with substances like tramadol. Shockingly, the Mental Health Authority noted in 2023 that 3,765 cases of mental disorders were linked to alcohol, and 5,554 to other psychoactive substances, predominantly affecting the 20 to 34 age group, with children as young as 10 to 14 presenting substance-related conditions.

Mr Speaker, a disturbing social media trend known as “Wonim Red” or “Red 225” has emerged, linked to the abuse of an unlicensed combination of tapentadol and carisoprodol, known as Super Royal 225. This dangerous substance poses severe risks including seizures, respiratory distress, and death. Videos of youth, some in school uniforms engaging in substance use have reflected on social media, normalising the perilous behaviour and amplifying the crisis.

Ghana’s current rehabilitation infrastructure is woefully inadequate. Facilities like Pantang Hospital, Accra

Psychiatric Hospital, and Ankafu Psychiatric Hospital are overstretched, with limited capacity to meet the growing demand for counselling, detoxification, and rehabilitation. Access to residential rehabilitation, particularly in Accra and other regions, remains severely constrained.

Mr Speaker, to address this public health crisis and align with the Global Call for Action, I propose the following urgent measures:

1. Establishment of Regional Rehabilitation Centres: The creation of well-funded, state-of-the-art rehabilitation centres in every region, staffed with trained professionals to provide comprehensive care, including detoxification, counselling, and reintegration programmes.
2. Strengthened Public Awareness Campaign: Intensify nationwide campaigns through traditional media, community outreach, and social media to educate the public on the dangers of substance abuse.
3. Regulation and Monitoring of Harmful Substances and Trends: Collaborate with the Narcotics Control Commission (NACOC), Food and Drug Authority (FDA), and cyber security agencies to regulate the sale of prescription drugs like Tramadol and monitor social media platforms to curb the spread of harmful trends.

4. Investment in Data-Driven Policies: Leverage research and data collection, as emphasised by this year's theme; to inform targeted interventions, drawing inspiration from global successes like Portugal's model of prioritising treatment over punishment.

Mr Speaker, the escalating rates of drug abuse among Ghanaian Youth threatens the future of our nation. On this International Drug Day, let us reaffirm our commitment to a people-centered approach that prioritises prevention, rehabilitation, and the elimination of stigma. The time to act is now.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to address this critical issue.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member.

I will now give the floor to Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, Esq.

Surge of Drug Abuse Among Ghanaian Youth

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija-Gbawe): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I rise today to draw the attention of this august House to a pressing national issue. Mr Speaker, the alarming surge in drug abuse among Ghana's youth, with particular emphasis on the widespread misuse of Tramadol 225mg, commonly referred to in the street vernacular as "Red".

Mr Speaker, this drug, originally intended for critical and clinical pain relief, has now taken hold of entire communities, particularly in Accra and Kumasi, in the ghettos, under the Circle overpass, around riversides, and the infamous enclave of Columbia in Krofuom, Kumasi. "Red" has become the new street king. It is devastating to witness vibrant young Ghanaians lose their futures to addiction. Mr Speaker, "Red" is not just a tablet—It has become a trap, one dragging down the energy, creativity, and promise of our youth.

Mr Speaker, what makes this situation even more troubling is that many of those affected express a genuine desire to seek help and recover. However, they face significant barriers in assessing treatment. The high cost of rehabilitation services remains a substantial obstacle, with fees reportedly reaching as high as GHC3,000.00, amounts far beyond the means of most affected youth, many of whom are unemployed, school dropouts, orphans, engaged in hand-to-mouth activities.

Mr Speaker, I wish to acknowledge the commendable efforts of Mr Godwin Asediba, a broadcast journalist, for his documentary on drug abuse in Ghana, and Mr Kwame Bekoe, my Constituency Youth Organiser, for his "Womin Red Campaign". Mr Speaker, this has helped shed light on the crisis. These initiatives have been very instrumental in raising public awareness and fostering critical discourse on drug abuse among the youth. I also wish to acknowledge Hon Frank Asiedu Bekoe (Protozoa) for his contribution on this matter.

Mr Speaker, it is clear that the battle against drug abuse cannot be won by the government alone. I therefore make a clarion call to:

First, the Ministry of Health to expand access to affordable community-based rehabilitation services and intensify street campaigns and public education programmes on drug abuse prevention and treatment. Existing facilities such as the Accra Psychiatric Hospital and Pantang Psychiatric Hospital should be expanded, made more youth-friendly and easily accessible.

Second, Mr Speaker, the Food and Drugs Authority to strengthen their regulatory frameworks governing the importation, distribution and retail of tramadol and other controlled substances, with improved enforcement mechanisms.

6.28 p.m.

I commend the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Authority for efforts made thus far, and I encourage the Authority to continue strictly enforcing existing regulations.

Third, religious institutions, faith-based organisations, and traditional authorities play a proactive role in rehabilitation and reintegration efforts, using their influence to drive anti-drug messages within communities.

Fourth, Civil Society Organisations and Non-Governmental Organisations to partner with the government in

providing recovery support and creating alternative pathways that give addicted youth hope and purpose.

Mr Speaker, lastly, to my Hon Colleagues, let us extend a helping hand to the young people in our respective constituencies. Let us organise regular health talks and outreach programmes to identify and support victims of drug abuse.

To parents, guardians, siblings, and family members, I urge you not to turn away from relatives struggling with addiction. Instead, support them where possible. Refer them to the appropriate authorities and health agencies for timely intervention and rehabilitation.

Mr Speaker, we must treat this crisis not merely as a law enforcement issue, but as a public health emergency. Let us act with urgency, and let us reclaim our youth. Let us protect Ghana's future, and let us stop "Red". *Wo nim "Red"?* Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member. I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Mahmoud Issifu, Member of Parliament for Binduri.

International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking

Mr Mahmoud Issifu (NDC — Binduri): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me this wonderful opportunity to contribute my quota on this International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking. *[Inaudible]*. 26th June has been proclaimed by the

United Nations General Assembly in 1987, as a day to remind countries across the globe about the debilitating impact of drug abuse and the illicit trafficking, calling on all of us to take deliberate action to stem its devastating tides. The relevance of the theme for this year's commemoration "The Evidence is Clear: Invest in Prevention" is timely and instructive within the context of what we are witnessing of drug abuse and its raving impact in our communities.

Drug abuse and illicit trafficking remains a persistent threat to the Ghanaian society. The menace is destroying families, eroding the moral fabric of our youth and future generations, fuelling crime in our communities and burdening our health infrastructure and budget as a country. The fight against drug abuse and illicit trafficking is not one for the government alone, but a shared responsibility across the segments of our society involving families, communities, civil society, individuals and the media.

The Ghanaian story may not be markedly different from its peers across the continent, where we are witnessing worrying trends of rising addiction among young people, increasing availability of synthetic and hard drugs and the activities of local as well as international trafficking networks exploiting the vulnerabilities of our young people.

As a country with a youthful population, the challenges of drug abuse and illicit trafficking conspires to undermine our national development pace; it actually compromises our peace

and security as a country. Laws or criminal justice operations and policies alone will not sufficiently resolve the menace. We must be concerned about intentionally addressing the social drivers of drug abuse and illicit trafficking drivers such as poverty, unemployment, trauma, lack of opportunities and ensuring that every citizen, especially our young people, have access to the support and the education they need to make informed choices in their lives.

Mr Speaker, the Government of Ghana, under H.E John Dramani Mahama remains very committed to the development and empowerment of young people, and therefore is marshalling the required determination to fight drug abuse and illicit trafficking on all fronts. The strategy of the reset agenda in preventing this menace of drug abuse and illicit trafficking, in this regard, revolves around a strong inter-agency collaboration, where the Ministry of Health and all other relevant agencies, including border and port authorities have been activated and placed on the lookout for these drugs, their peddlers and collaborators across the country.

The government is also investing in youth empowerment programmes such as Adwumawura programme, the One Million Coders Programme, Youth Apprenticeship Programme and the various youth employment modules being rolled out by the Youth Employment Agency (YEA). All of these initiatives are intentionally aiming at rechannelling the passion and energies of our young people into productive ventures.

The Government is also looking at mainstreaming community initiatives of volunteer groups against drug abuse, especially the recent initiative started by the youth in Nima. We shall strive to ensure that such initiatives operate with regular state security supervision and within the confines of due process of law.

I wish to call on all Ghanaians especially, we the Members of this august House to use this day to pause and reflect on the devastations that the problem of drug abuse and illicit trafficking wrecks on our young people.

6.38 p.m.

Join me to say no to drugs, drug Abuse and trafficking, and yes to the protection of the life, health and the dignity of our young people. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Order!

It is now the turn of Hon Godwin Animli Dorgbadzi-Dorani. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Abuse of Opioids

Mr Godwin Animli Dorgbadzi-Dorani (NDC — Adansi Asokwa): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to give this Statement on International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking.

Mr Speaker, the International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking is observed globally on 26th

June every year. This year, the slogan for the event is, “Breaking the Chains, Prevention, Treatment, and Recovery for All”. On this day, we are invited to not relent on our responsibility to protect our communities, especially, our youth from the crippling effects of drug abuse.

Mr Speaker, the World Drug Report 2024, shows that globally, the prevalence rate of opioid abuse is 1.15 per cent and 1.26 per cent in Africa. Also, the data indicates that trend change shows that there is a large increase, more than 10 per cent, in opioid abuse in Ghana. In terms of prevalence, opioids rank third after cannabis and cocaine, respectively.

Mr Speaker, in recent times, the future of our nation has been under serious attack. The phenomenon of drug abuse now more than ever, exhibits enormous danger. The alarming rate of devastation and destruction we all observe in the youth, in the streets, and ghettos within our constituencies is very worrying. Mr Speaker, the infamous slogan, “*wonim red?*”, in the Ghanaian streets and public places speak volumes. The pharmaceutical drugs known as Red-225, originally made to manage pain, is now a source of pain in some cycles of our society due to abuse.

Mr Speaker, on the 28th May, 2025, I watched a documentary aired on TV3 titled “*Hooked on Red*”. I am more than convinced that our human resource is under siege. Mr Speaker, if care is not taken, the rate of destruction the abuse of pharmaceutical opioids is inflicting on our youth can be likened to a silent epidemic which would bring the future

of the nation to a standstill. The very future we seek to build by dint of hard work will be of no use. I would like to urge this august House to pay attention to this phenomenon and fight it with all the energy it deserves. I also want to invite all well-meaning Ghanaians, from the media practitioners, religious leaders, and traditional leaders, to join in the move by the Ministry for Youth Development and Empowerment to wade into the campaign “Red Means Stop”, while reassuring the youth of better days ahead.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, the floor is now open for comments.

Hon James Agalga, you have the floor.

Mr James Agalga (NDC — Builsa North): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Statements ably made by four of our Colleagues in commemoration of World Drug Day.

Mr Speaker, illicit drug trafficking in this country is a major problem that has to be dealt with once and for all. But to be able to execute this task very effectively, we need inter-agency collaboration among the security agencies of our state. In recent times, I have seen them collaborate very effectively. And such collaboration actually resulted in the interception of a tipper truck along the Accra-Cape Coast Highway. Mr Speaker, the volume of

cocaine intercepted is worthy of mention. 3.3 tonnes of cocaine was intercepted. And this was through the collaboration of our security agencies, namely, the Narcotics Control Commission and the National Investigations Bureau. This is commendable.

Mr Speaker, on 4th June, the cocaine in question was destroyed in accordance with the Narcotics Control Commission Act, Act 2020. Mr Speaker, but inter-agency collaboration has not always been effective, which is why we probably have to harmonise our laws relative to drug law enforcement to ensure that they do not insist on protecting turf when they are combating illicit drug trafficking. I will just give you an example to buttress the point. In 2020, cocaine was intercepted at the Kpoglu border in the Ketu South Municipality and this happened on the 5th June, 2020. An amount of 100.10 grammes of cocaine was seized. At the end of the day—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us take into consideration the limited duration of five minutes.

Thank you.

Mr Agalga: At the end of the day, due to misunderstanding between the securities agencies involved at the border, the cocaine went missing. So, this is the type of collaboration I am talking about.

Mr Speaker, most importantly, let me indicate that this House, in 2020, enacted legislation on drug use and addiction. Mr Speaker, with your kind permission, I

want to refer to section 22 of the Narcotic Control Commission Act 2020, which reads as follows:

- “(1) There is established by this Act, a Substance Use Disorder Rehabilitation Fund, referred to in this Act as the “Fund”.
- (2) The Commission shall use the Fund to rehabilitate a person medically certified to be suffering from substance use disorder.”

Mr Speaker, this was an important intervention made by this House to address the issue of drug use disorder. This was a bold attempt to decriminalise drug use disorder. Mr Speaker, unfortunately, the attempt was incomplete, because if we look at the Act in question, drug use disorder is still punishable under the law.

6.48 p.m.

So, if one is an addict and they are brought before the court, the hands of the courts are tied. The court must first convict before they can make a referral of the convict for rehabilitation, but that is problematic. That is problematic because somebody suffering from drug use disorder is a sick person. So, that tag of handing down a conviction before making a referral for the person to be helped is incongruous. Even in the face of the provision which now seeks to set up a rehabilitation fund and so on and so forth. I believe it is high time we took a second look at our drug enforcement law and maybe, modify it once again. Let us amend it.

At the time when the Act came before this House, some of us had argued that it was time for us to completely decriminalise drug use disorder, but at the time, our arguments did not find favour with majority of us in this House. Now that drug use disorder has become a major problem, I believe that next time, when we have the opportunity, we will do what is right.

So, with these few words, I want to congratulate the makers of the Statement for doing justice to the day in question, World Drugs Day.

Thank you very much for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the Statement ably made by the four Hon Members. The issue of drug abuse and illicit drug trafficking is something that we should not take lightly. I am just sitting here trying to ponder over what is happening in my constituency. Specifically, any time I go to my constituency, I spend time to go to the ghettos. The ghettos at Akumadan, Nkenkaasu, Afrancho, and even some of the small towns within the Nsenoa area.

I ask them why they are spending that time there. In fact, they are seated under trees with no chairs and sometimes, within a bush, not considering what could happen from wild animals. This is something I ask myself, that it could have happened to me, it could have happened to anyone or our sister or our child. What do we have to do to be able to break this chain?

Mr Speaker, we need to look at what is causing this drug abuse; every single illicit drug traffic will lead to a drug abuse. It happens at an early age when people are uneducated and do not have access to education. So, people abuse them by introducing them to drugs. When people are unemployed, there is a saying that an idle hand will always find something bad to do. We, as a country, should not just make it a commemorative speech or day, but we have to take it seriously.

Now, the current trend is not just one drug. It is what is called polysubstance abuse. Now, we have people not only taking cocaine or heroin or meth or what we call “red”, but they are taking a whole series of drugs which makes them useless and they are not able to support themselves. Some sleep while working. It is a serious issue. We, as Parliament, should not just spend a day to make Statements, but we should have a strategic approach. I believe we spoke about this some time ago, where I made mention of the fact that drug abuse is like a bomb being dropped into Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the sad part of this whole issue is that now, in Ghana, people have started manufacturing methamphetamines. This is what we call the “meth lab” in the advanced nations. It has cost them a lot of money and we have not paid attention to it. Like I said, when I was in pharmacy school, Tramadol was just learnt in books. Now, we have access to 225mg Tramadol on the market and we are spending so much money to kill our young ones to make them good for nothing. We have to look at it.

Methamphetamine labs are starting to be in Ghana now and we should not wait. The security services, Food and Drugs Authority (FDA)—Now, we know that a drug like pseudoephedrine, which is for common cold, can be used to produce a methamphetamine which is a class two drug that can lead to drug abuse. What are we doing? We have to make sure that, at least, what other countries have gone through, we do not have to go down that same road. It is going to cost us a lot.

This is the time that we have to set some strategies in place. As Government, as Parliament and as a country, we have to have a strategy. This is because the one that would hit us and kill us is the methamphetamine labs, which have started in the cities: Accra, Kumasi, Takoradi and the rest, so if we think that the “red” and Tramadol is costing a lot, if we do not stop it now, this country cannot contain it.

We are a population of just about 33 million. We need every single young one to support the development of this nation. Every young man or woman is proud to be a Ghanaian and we have to support them. That means that we have to take education at the early stages very seriously. Employment issues need to be looked at and for those that are benefiting from these illicit drugs, we have to look at it and see how best we can save these young ones. This is because every young Ghanaian that we save today, can be a hero in the future. I believe we all have a collective objective, will and power to work at it. That if we work at it and work together as one nation, drug abuse and illicit drugs can, at least, be reduced if it cannot be a thing of the past.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. I will give the floor to Prof Titus Beyuo.

Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo (NDC — Lambussie): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to these important Statements made by four of our Colleagues on this very important day. Mr Speaker, I believe today is more realistic and easily appreciated in our country because of the devastating effects of opioids. The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), put the theme for today as, “Break the Cycle, Stop Organised Crime”.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, organised crime is driving the illicit trade of drugs, which is having very devastating effects on our youth in this country. For us to be able to break the cycle, we need to observe very closely the changing trend of drug abuse in this country. It is an organised crime because we have industries that are willing to produce these poisons for our youth, businessmen who are willing to import these drugs into our country and people who are willing to distribute them to the youth. In the ghettos, the level of organisation there is now even more sophisticated.

Mr Speaker, we must also be very worried about the unequal distribution of these drugs in the country and if we do not get that trend right, we cannot break the cycle.

6.58 p.m.

Data suggests that in the *galamsey* areas, the consumption of these illicit drugs are very high.

In the border towns, there are very high levels of these drugs. The new trend is that they are imported under the pretext of being shipped out of this country and therefore the necessary scrutiny at the port of entry is not conducted. The laws do not permit the FDA to fully inspect containers that are meant for transit to other countries. They only cross our land borders and then brought back into the country. They are evading our security systems because the police do not find them when they are sent to the ghettos.

The Pharmacy Council is helpless. FDA is getting helpless because these drugs are no more sold in the drug stores or chemical shops. They have ghetto kings and people are selling phone cases with “red” in it. When they meet their willing customers, there are ways they communicate. So, one will see someone hawking with phone cases, chargers or cables, but the person is carrying “red”. How would the police even identify such a person to arrest? But when he gets to the ghetto, the people know themselves and they will talk to each other and find a way of trading in it. So, we have to get our security services to descend into the ghettos, link up with these ghetto kings and be able to track and we also want to make sure that we do not leave anyone behind as far as the treatment is concerned.

Mr Speaker, I insist that for a country like Ghana, our best bet is prevention, not treatment. Therapy or rehabilitation for drug addiction is very expensive. We do not have public facilities available for this.

The Pantang Psychiatric Hospital that has a rehabilitation centre is poorly equipped. Apart from Pantang Psychiatric Hospital, you will not find any proper rehabilitation set up in any public institution. So, for a condition as widespread as this, our solution is not the therapy or the treatment. It should be the prevention.

I therefore join other Colleagues who have called on the security agencies, but I am encouraging them that they must be mindful of the new trends that if they go in police vehicles, they will find nobody to arrest. They have to find a way of partnering these kings and ghetto gangsters to lead them to the people and perhaps it should not be punitive initially. We should look at how to reach out to these people and try and help them and in so doing, we will be able to handle this.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement. I am grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Yes, any indication?

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I can see that Members have a lot of interest to contribute. But if we want to allow all Members, we will sleep here. So, we could allow Leadership to conclude so that next time we get opportunity to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Leadership.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the practice as I have known it to be when I was in the black chair to your right, was that when a request is made by the Speaker regarding indication, the other Side is consulted. This I did—And we have to judge the mood of the House.

Mr Speaker, this issue of drug abuse is a matter of grave national concern. What is the time? It is just 7.00 p.m. We have stayed here up to midnight before, even up to 2.00 a.m. How can it ever be that on an important issue that has brought four Members to make Statements, we will rush the Speaker to say that if we allow the many who are willing to add their voice, we may sleep here. This is the people's platform.

Mr Speaker, if the application has been withdrawn as prayed, it is in your hands. So, Mr Speaker, please admit as many as are willing, especially the women, to make their contribution before Leadership comes in.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Millicent Yeboah Amankwah.

Ms Millicent Yeboah Amankwah (NDC — Sunyani West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the Statements on the International Day of Drug Abuse.

Mr Speaker, drug abuse is actually a societal problem which all the Members

in this House, one way or the other, encounter in the Constituency.

Even though we have well-structured institutions that need to help us in this regard, Mr Speaker, some of the major causes from my perspective is the foundation. That is from the family. There are some cases where these young ones who find themselves in this situation are coming from broken homes. But notwithstanding, that is not a guarantee to engage in that because even in this House, we have some Members who were groomed and mentored or taken care of by a single parent.

But, Mr Speaker, when you engage these young ones, these are some of the major issues that led to that. But I believe that sometimes it is because of child rights and human rights that in our society now we do not have the right to train, educate and mentor someone who is going wrong. We really need to take a look at it.

Another issue is unemployment. Because of the high rate of unemployment, there is much depression among the young ones in our communities. I was really happy when one of our Hon Members who made a Statement indicated that His Excellency John Dramani Mahama will offer many employment opportunities under YEA, Adwumawura, and many other programmes.

Another thing we need to pay much key attention to are the agents who are involved in this menace. Because, Mr Speaker, I keep on saying that these

things that are happening, we are also part of the cause. I remember when I met my traditional rulers the last time, I said anyone who is involved as an agent selling these drugs to the young ones, we need to really talk to them because they are our family members. We all need to contribute our quota to solve these drug abuse menace. So, if you see someone selling it, you should as a traditional leader call the person to order. It is not about the money; it is about the future of the community and the nation at large. So, it is one thing we really need to look at.

Mr Speaker, I would urge the security agencies—Because sometimes they embark on exercise to arrest people who are engaged in drug abuse. By the time they get there, the people are already aware that the police are coming. It is a hearsay that some of the police personnel are also engaged in drug abuse. I believe that if they are not engaged in drug abuse, they can lace their boots well and make sure that we put an end to this.

Mr Speaker, I believe that this is an urgent matter and all Members in this House need to come together to find a way to contribute to the fight against this menace of drug abuse. It could be in a form of capacity building and some training for us to get closer to these young ones so that at the end the future will be bright as we end the menace.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Fred Agbenyo.

Mr Fred Kwesi Agbenyo (NDC — Guan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Let me start off by thanking the makers of these Statements and those who have contributed to it.

7.08 p.m.

Mr Speaker, combating drug abuse in Ghana requires a multi-sectoral approach and the involvement of the family. It requires the involvement of the educational institutions, health sector, security services, media and civil society organisations.

Mr Speaker, we can all pretend that we do not know what is happening in our country, in our constituencies and in our family homes. The time has come, Mr Speaker, for us to call a spade a spade if we are to nip this issue in the bud. The causes of drug abuse are things that, even in basic schools, one reads in textbooks. So, we all know the causes. We all know the solutions.

But the question is, Mr Speaker, as a nation, what pragmatic steps are we taking to resolve this particular issue? Now, most of the drugs we are complaining about come from outside this country. We have persons we have engaged to man our borders for us. Mr Speaker, what is happening at our entry points? We all know some of these fisher folks. When they bring the drugs, they give them to the canoe operators who use unapproved routes to bring them to the country. The customs officers are aware.

The Police Service is aware. And all the people who are supposed to check these things are aware that this is going on. But for whatever reason, Mr Speaker, we seem to be glossing over it and pretending as though we do not know what is going on.

Now, these days, if we go to our constituencies, Mr Speaker, and see what is becoming of the young people, indeed, it is worrying when an issue like this is brought to the fore for discussion. Young people wake up in the morning, and they do not know where their next meal will come from. They have no form of employment. And so, out of some form of frustration, they think the only way they can keep themselves going is by engaging in these illicit drugs.

Mr Speaker, people are engaged in cannabis farming, even though I am told the law has been passed in this House. But officially, they have not allowed people to do it, especially the medicinal one. But all over the place, we know people are engaged in the farming. And we know the vehicles that are loading and bringing it to the cities. They pass by the police barriers at night. And so, I do not think that this issue is an issue we can pretend we do not know the source or how to combat it.

I think that our political will to play a role and subdue the problem is what is creating the problem we are having today. Let us go to almost all the drug stores around town, and see the kind of drugs they sell. They put them under the desks, under the tables, and like one of the contributors said, when it is time to go to buy, it is as if they have a

communication between them. As soon as the gentleman walks in, they know what he is looking for. Quickly, they pick it up and give it to him, they collect their money, and he goes. He does not even need to open his mouth. So they are from a cabal, a team. They know themselves.

So, it is sometimes very difficult to even arrest them. What we need to do is to use more intelligence gathering. We cannot use the normal policing system to arrest those who are involved in these activities.

Mr Speaker, I want to really thank the maker of the Statement and call on you and the House that this must not be a subject that we will just contribute to, but something concrete must be done. We need to be able to call all the institutions on board and see how we can find a solution. When all of us went to secondary school, if one was privileged not to get involved in some of these things, one was called a *colo* boy who did not understand anything.

So, if one gets to first year, and is not fortunate and finds themselves among boys who know how to do these things, quickly, under peer pressure, one is introduced to it, and before one says jack, one becomes something else.

Mr Speaker, let us see how we can combat this. Those from the health sector have told us that in the hospitals, we do not have the facilities to reform those who are involved in these things. What can we do immediately to try to minimise it? I do not think we can stop it completely, but we can take steps that can minimise the importation of the

drugs into the country. And put a check on those who are producing them in the country, as well as those who are distributing them.

Mr Speaker, once we are able to restrict the activity, Mr Speaker, I believe that this menace will reduce drastically. I thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, what do we do? We have a Statement from Hon Clement Apaak on disability.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if it pleases you, we may take one more from each Side and come to Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member.

Mr Ernest Adomako (NDC — Okaikwei South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by my Colleagues.

Mr Speaker, these hard drugs are destroying the youth of this country and our future. I think that the Ministry of Education should, at least once in a while, do a random blood test, because the Government is spending so much money on free education, and yet these kids come back from school and become a liability.

So, I think when school reopens, Ministry of Education, may do random blood tests, and those who are taking these hard drugs can be expelled from

our schools, because the Government cannot spend so much money on free education, and then after school, they become a liability.

Mr Speaker, we all have a responsibility to make sure that we minimise these hard drugs, because it is destroying the future of this country.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leadership.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me take this opportunity to thank you for at least granting four of the Members the leave to make a Statement on this important matter that affects our nation, particularly our youth.

Mr Speaker, today is the International Day against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking. Listening to all those who made this Statement and various contributions, it is very clear that the menace of drug use and trafficking is a problem in our country. It is the reason this day is globally being recognised as a day to speak against this menace. So, we commemorate this day.

Mr Speaker, the United Nations could not have done anything less. As the Member for Okaikwei South just said, after spending so much on free education, instead of benefiting from the human resource development as a result of the investment, the nation will now have to spend more money on rehabilitation and all.

7.16 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I would first enjoin all parents to take an interest in the upbringing of their children. It is not the responsibility of the teachers alone. And if I am referring to parents, the first point of call is this very House. Oftentimes, political leaders and public office holders become so busy that they do not know that when their kids get to their teenage years, that is the period that the kids need them the most. We can see our children go wayward and yell as much as we can, but we are the problem.

Mr Speaker, time may not permit for this very point to be expanded, but there is every gain in, as parents, paying attention to the upbringing of our children. So let us not shift the blame. Even as we are busy in our public duties, let us find time to sit with our children. When we get home, we should not assume that they are asleep and become too busy the next morning that it only becomes the responsibility of our spouses. We should not be too busy because most of the problems is not only about those who are poor; the homes of the middle-class and upper-class are also suffering now.

Can we imagine spending all our money to investment in building, making some properties and setting up some businesses for our children to sit in planes, flying here and there in business and economic class and attending big schools abroad. They later come home with questionable hairstyles and some ideologies and behaviours in our old age because we did not take time to invest in

counselling them. And we ask ourselves, *na who cause am?*

Mr Speaker, I emphasise that we in this House, those of us who are in the public service, our Parliamentary Service staff should not be too busy with their work. They should spend time with their kids, especially, as they approach teenage. That is the most dangerous period in the upbringing of every child.

Mr Speaker, for these youngsters, there is something they now call vape. It is replacing the known cigarettes that people know and that is how they start. These youngsters also go into the schools with these “edibles”. They have their own way of influencing these students, making them believe that if they take it, they will feel good.

Mr Speaker, if I knew this matter was going to be discussed today, I would have sought permission to share a story, but I do not have permission. But I believe a time will come when I will share that real life experience of a situation that I encountered in certain quarters. We as parents must not say that it is somebody's responsibility. If the child is in a boarding house, visit them. Be open with your kids; talk to them about sex, discuss everything. Our upbringing of yesterday is not the same as today. They know more than we do. We should not underestimate them. They know about everything.

So, we should be bold, sit with them, share with them and we will get to know a lot. Through that, we will save their lives because if we do not share with our children, somebody will misinform or

miseducate them. That would become a burden on us.

Mr Speaker, once upon a time, I visited a Member in this House, and when I saw the relationship between this Member and her adult kids, I asked if they were siblings. I later had the benefit of interacting with a teenage counsellor who asked me to read some materials. If we relate to them, they would feel comfortable and they place their trust in us. I then said, “this woman is doing it right”. The children will not go wayward.

Mr Speaker, I am getting very emotional on this matter because I know a lot of us are losing our kids and we cannot talk about it. All the investments—I am lucky by the grace of God, that I had the benefit of knowing how to approach these situations. My firstborn is in the medical school, my second born is studying Law, and my third born has become a great student. My eyes are still on them, but somebody may not be as lucky. Let us talk about everything because there are a lot of things happening in the schools. The teachers alone cannot do it.

Mr Speaker, I having addressed that important point, let me now deal with the poverty related issues. Truly, our Sister Millicent Amankwah emphasised how single parenting also creates such platforms. Because people introduce these drugs to kids of single parents who are helpless and poor. How do we combat it? We as political leaders must be very brave, confront the situation and act proactively. I am only hazarding a guess, but maybe, in the political

campaigning, they may appear useful, but someday they may be a burden on us. If we pay attention to help them out of the situation, they become a benefit to society.

Mr Speaker, the last point before I take my seat is on this perception—I do not know how the media will carry this last point but I will still say it. I do not know what has become of men that every man wants “manpower”. These young men, they—Well, for now, let me discuss the “manpower”. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I really do not know what these young men want to achieve. We see them chasing these drugs because they claim they will have “a long journey”. Then, in the process, they find themselves in such a situation. After they have had their “long journey”, then we see that cannot move; they sleepwalk or whatever. Is it really the case that the woman they want to impress get impressed through long journey?

7.28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if we go to our hospitals today— maybe we should invite the Minister for Health to share some statistics— we see young men with renal-related diseases going for dialysis.

Dialysis at age 25 or 30? Do you have a liver problem at age 30? It is a lifestyle related matter; you see a 70-year-old man walking *gigim*, *gigim*, without having to use these drugs.

Mr Speaker, I would want to join my Colleagues, with these three important points, in encouraging Government to intensify public education on this matter.

Getting facilities or expanding psychiatric facilities, in my view, would not be the solution; we should invest in the preventives. That would be the way out and, above all, at the risk of repeating myself, parents should keep to their primary obligation. The Book of Ephesians reminds us of our responsibility as parents and we should keep to that.

Mr Speaker, without more, I would want to rest my case on this matter.

Thank you so much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member.

Yes, I will give the floor to Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe.

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement made by my Colleague on drug abuse.

Mr Speaker, this has become a problem for the youth and I, as a woman, do not blame the youth when they get into drug situations. At times parents need to keep their eyes on the environment where they live and how they treat their young ones, thus, their children. Every small problem they say that they do not want to see their children in their house. For days, they will keep saying they do not want to see them. Where do they want that child to go? They will mingle with those who are into drugs and, by the time you realise, that child too has become part of the problem that Ghana wants to solve.

Mr Speaker, if you sit these children down – the ghetto boys and the youth who are into drug – you would realise that a lot of them are clever. A lot of them passed their examination and a lot of them also do not have support. So, they have no option and jobs. In our areas, how many ghettos do we have? How many of them have we spoken to? How many of them have we tried to change their lives? Let us work together to pick one or two of them and find out which level they have reached and whether they would like to go to secondary school. Let us support them.

When we are even giving jobs to the youth, do we remember them? Do we remember to enter the ghettos? Because if we pick them one after the other and there is nobody in there, that ghetto will collapse because there is nobody to sit there. We rather see them as evil people; no, they are not.

Let us rather see them as some of us who are having problems. Let us see how best we can help them solve those problems, so that we will dissolve all those ghettos. If they are busy, how would they go there? We have people who had been in the ghettos and they are now occupying high positions. How did they get there? It is because somebody helped them. A lot of them had the support to be educated, so, as Ghanaians, let us work together. Those children are our children; it should not be a child that comes from one's womb alone.

As MPs, we have a way of sponsoring students who need to continue their education; we have to

make some provisions for them. Let us enter the ghettos and ask how many would like to continue their education., so that we help them do that. We should ask them about their houses and take them there to be united with their parents. A lot of the parents too shy away when they see their children in that situation. Instead of calming, pampering, and bringing them to their side and guiding them to know the difference, they do not do that, but they would start cursing: *wo bebre; Nyame betua wo ka; m'abɔ wo ho ka, enɛ hwɛ baabi a, wo te; hwɛ deɛ woreye wo ho*. To wit, you will suffer. We should stop it and rather give them love. For me, I see drug abuse as a disease that we need to cure and how do we cure it? Let us give them love; let us provide for them and ensure they are also educated. Let us make sure that we do not discriminate against the ones that are in the house.

Mr Speaker, if we can sacrifice a bit as a nation—This Youth Employment Agency and other initiatives, how many of them are we ready to employ? They will work. As you see them there, 90 per cent of them are not thieves; only about 2 or 5 per cent of them may be thieves. But most of them are not thieves. It is frustration that has set in and they have nowhere to go. So, let us organise a programme for them. We have rehabilitation centres; how are we using them?

How much and how many of them has the Ministry of Health programmed to be taken to rehabilitation centres? Because they are all sick people. If one is into drugs and addicted, then they are

sick. We have to cure them because if one eats too much and you have high blood pressure, they take high blood pressure drugs. If they are taking too much drugs and they are addicted to it, they need doctors who cure them, and we have them. We have psychologists.

Let me use this opportunity to greet one psychologist in Korle Bu Teaching Hospital, Mr Logosu Amegashie. He has been doing well when it comes to drug abuse and has been helping the youth who are into it.

Let us change our perception towards them. Parents who gave birth to these children in those situations should not neglect them. They should bring them closer and calm them down. They should not fight them because the more they fight them, the more they run away from their house. So, let us bring them closer, talk to them and give them more education. They will be somewhere. Can we not see a lot of big men who smoke but are in big positions? So, what shows that those children cannot also occupy those positions if they are given all the needed support?

I am pleading with all the 275 MPs to go to the ghettos and see how many they can change. We have education funds, so how many of them can we send back to school? How many of those in junior high school can we send to senior high school? How many of them have finished senior high school and can enter into meaningful jobs?

Mr Speaker, we need to change our perception towards them and advise all parents who have their children in that

situation to rather embrace them, bring them closer and ensure they give them whatever they will need as kids, so that they will become good leaders in future.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I direct that the four Statements be transmitted to the Minister for Health.

Hon Members, may we take the Statement on disability.

Yes, Hon Apaak, you have the floor.

Dr Apaak: Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to make a Statement in commemoration of the 2025 National Day of Persons with Disabilities—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

7.38 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I believe that our respected Colleague, who is also the Deputy Minister of Education, even if he makes it in his capacity as a Member of Parliament and not as a Deputy Minister—

Mr Speaker, I will pray that he comes forward, with the leave of the Frontbench, to address us. This is because it is an important matter, so he cannot stay in obscurity to make such an important Statement. He is a Deputy Minister. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, he is a Deputy Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, with all due respect, he can be heard wherever he is. So, Hon Apaak—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is why I am asking—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Apaak, please, you have the floor.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, is he making it in his capacity as the Deputy Minister?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I have the Statement before me; there is nothing here in the capacity as a Deputy Minister.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you have been accommodating all day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I am accommodating, but I have the Statement before me.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you have been all smiles the whole of today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am smiling.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, but you are not smiling now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am not angry, so Hon Deputy Minister, you have the floor.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The man can come forward and then make his Statement; he is too far away.

STATEMENT

National Day of Persons with Disability, 2025

Dr Clement Abas Apaak (NDC — Builsa South): Mr Speaker, I must appreciate the sudden expression of love towards me by the Minority Leader. It is well appreciated; let me indulge him to be patient with me because I believe the Statement I am going to make would elicit some very important contributions from him.

Mr Speaker, please, accept my sincerest gratitude to you and the Leadership of this august House for granting me this unique opportunity to make a Statement in commemoration of this year's National Day of Persons with Disability, which was observed on 23rd June, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the National Day of Persons with Disability was instituted by the Ghana Federation of Disability Organisations (GFD) to mark the passage of the Persons with Disability Act, 2006 (Act 715). It was instituted a year after the passage of the Act and has since been observed since 23rd June, 2007.

Mr Speaker, on behalf of the Parliamentary Caucus on Disability and the Ghana Federation of Disability Organisations (GFD), I commend the Rt Hon Speaker of Parliament, Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin, for inaugurating the Parliamentary Caucus

on Disability almost a year ago. This milestone was achieved after years of persistent advocacy by the GFD, supported by Sightsavers and Ghana Somubi Dwumadie.

Parliamentary Caucus on Disability: Objective and Role

Mr Speaker, the Parliamentary Caucus on Disability has championed the cause of PwDs. We want to ensure that legislations passed by this House is disability inclusive and that Parliament remains accessible to PwDs. The Caucus has also advocated the expedited reenactment of the Persons with Disability Act, 2006 (Act 715), and the ratification of the African Disability Protocol. The objective of the Caucus is to create a platform for parliamentarians to advocate for the rights and inclusion of PwDs, promote equal opportunities, and support the implementation of disability-related policies and legislations.

Mr Speaker, our objective is informed by the rather unpleasant fact that PwDs face various barriers to participation in society, including inaccessible infrastructure stigma and discrimination, limited access to education and employment, and inadequate healthcare and social services.

Our Caucus intends to help address these issues by:

- Raising awareness about disability issues among parliamentarians and the general public.

- Providing a forum for parliamentarians to discuss and address disability-related concerns.
- Supporting legislation and policies promoting disability inclusion.
- Engaging with organisations of PwDs and other stakeholders.

Mr Speaker, our focus, as a Caucus, is on disability issues in Ghana, including accessible infrastructure and transportation; education and employment opportunities; healthcare and social services; political participation and representation

Ghana Federation of Disability Organisations (GFD)

Mr Speaker, on 23rd June, 2025, the Ghana Federation of Disability Organisations (GFD) commemorated the 2025 National Day of Persons with Disabilities under the theme: “Advancing Inclusion through Education”. This theme represents not only a moral imperative but also a constitutional obligation to ensure that no child is left behind in our education system because of disability.

Mr Speaker, Ghana has made notable commitments to inclusive education. Section 18 of the Persons with Disability Act, 2006 (Act 715), and article 24 of the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD), which Ghana ratified in 2012, guaranteed the right of PwDs to inclusive education. These legal frameworks require us to establish an

education system that is not segregated but integrated, accessible, and empowering.

The Ministry of Education has implemented the Inclusive Education Policy (2015), established Special Education Units across districts, invested in braille and sign language materials, and begun incorporating inclusive practices into teacher training programmes.

However, Mr Speaker, despite these commendable efforts, the situation on the ground still falls short of the vision these policies seek to promote. Many children with disabilities remain out of school. Numerous schools lack accessible infrastructure. Teachers are often untrained in inclusive methodologies, and data on children with disabilities remains fragmented or non-existent, making it difficult to plan and allocate resources effectively. There are non-existent or, in many case, difficulty-to-reach places where students are actually denied access opportunities to gain an education.

Mr Speaker, attitudinal barriers and stigma, especially in rural areas, continue to deny thousands of children with disabilities not only their right to education but also their right to participate meaningfully in society.

What the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government is Doing for PwDs

Mr Speaker, the Government of Ghana needs support as it works to implement bold and progressive policies aimed at ensuring inclusion and accessibility at all levels.

Mathematics and Sign Language Curriculum for Visually and Hearing-Impaired Students.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, has announced the development of a Mathematics curriculum tailored for visually impaired students to enhance access to Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) education. Additionally, work is ongoing to establish a Ghanaian Sign Language Curriculum to support hearing-impaired learners.

Free Tertiary Education for Persons with Disabilities

Mr Speaker, education must be truly accessible, and no financial barrier should stand in the way of the dream of any child, including PwDs. PwDs will enjoy free tertiary education, enabling full participation in national development. The Hon Minister for Education has urged leaders within the disability community to register with the Student Loans Trust Fund (SLTF) to qualify under this policy. The Ministry, through Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC), is gathering data on students with disabilities to roll out the policy effectively.

7.48 p.m.

Mr Speaker, furthermore, a multi-stakeholder committee has been established by the Minister, and I, your Hon Colleague, am the co-chair of that Committee. I co-chair this Committee with Mr Joseph Atsu Homadzi, who is the President of the Ghana Federation of

Disability Organisations. We have been mandated to work out the roadmap to ensure that persons with disability, from kindergarten to university, obtain an education free of charge.

Re-enactment of Persons with Disability Act, 2006 (Act 715)

Mr Speaker, H.E John Dramani Mahama is committed to strengthening Ghana's legal framework for disability rights and prioritising the passage of the Persons with Disability Amendment Bill. In addition, His Excellency would introduce a legislative instrument (L.I.) to operationalise the re-enacted Act.

5 per cent Employment Quota for Persons with Disabilities

Mr Speaker, the Government is committed to partnering with private sector employers to ensure that at least 5 per cent of their competent workforce is recruited from the disability community. This is a critical step towards economic empowerment and workplace inclusion. We are confident that many qualified persons with disability are capable of holding key positions in our workforce.

Recommendations

Mr Speaker, we must ensure the full and comprehensive implementation of Ghana's Disability Act in its current form, even as we work to re-enact it. Mr Speaker, we must improve physical, structural, and informational accessibility in public spaces, transportation, healthcare, and educational institutions. This includes investing in disability-friendly infrastructure, assistive technologies, accessible educational

material, and adopting public facilities and transport systems to meet the needs of persons with disability.

Mr Speaker, we must conduct a nationwide sensitisation campaign to reduce stigma and discrimination and provide targeted training for educators, healthcare professionals, and employers on disability rights and inclusive practices. Persons with disability in Ghana and their representatives must be actively involved in the design, implementation, and evaluation of policies and programmes to ensure that their needs are met in their own voices.

Parliament of Ghana

Mr Speaker, I urge Members of Parliament to lead the charge not only in word but with decisive action. Inclusive education is not merely an education issue. It is a human rights issue, a social justice issue, and a national development issue.

Mr Speaker, I use this opportunity to humbly call on like-minded Colleagues to join the Parliamentary Caucus on Disability. I know there are many of us here who have this matter at heart. Take this opportunity to join the Parliamentary Caucus on Persons with Disability. I respectfully call on this House and the Government to officially adopt 23rd June as the National Day for Persons with Disability.

I am most grateful, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Deputy Minister for Education, for this very important Statement on the rights of Persons with Disability.

The floor is now open.

Yes, Hon Deh?

Mr Sebastian Fred Deh (NDC — Kpando): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity. Coming at a very late hour of the day, I will be very brief. I make this statement keeping in mind that beyond being a Member of this House, I am very passionate about issues of people with disability, particularly, because I am a proud father of one. I do everything possible to ensure that what the world is clamouring for, what the world speaks about and what we as humans try to teach ourselves and bring to the fore about people's needs to bring them at par with life as it ought to be led. We all know about it and it all starts by accepting that not all humans have the same opportunity, hence the word, "disability".

Mr Speaker, I am very happy that the maker of the Statement, my senior Colleague and the Deputy Minister for Education has announced to all of us that the Government has instituted something that he actually has been put in charge of. I am also happy that no less a person than the gentleman called Joseph Atsu, who I know very well. He himself is a person with a disability, and that gentleman, the erudite Deputy Minister himself being in charge of this and being the hard-working man as he is, I know that this issue will be pushed forward and then all the issues that were listed in the current National Democratic Congress (NDC) manifesto, which for me will be implemented to alleviate predicament of people with disability, will all be dealt with one after the other.

Let me be quick to mention that it is trite knowledge that currently we have on our hands certain measures that are supposed to be implemented to alleviate the predicament of these people and it includes giving free tertiary education to all persons with disability.

I think this is commendable and on a day like this where a Statement is made on the floor of this august House it needs to be mentioned. I can also say that being a member of the group of people who wrote the NDC manifesto that is being implemented now, issues of accessibility inclusion is well articulated in the document, issues of persons with disability are well articulated and linked to what we are implementing for Women's Development Bank. It is also very much linked to all employment opportunities that are being given to Ghanaians; people with disability are put at the forefront and they are given a better opportunity to access these things. So, this Statement, for me, is a very good one and must be accepted by all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. I will give the floor to Hon Joseph Kumah.

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement ably delivered by Dr Clement Apaak, the Deputy Minister for Education.

Mr Speaker, the issues about the disability is an issue that we must continue to talk about and to save them from the current existence. Mr Speaker, our policies and programmes must

intentionally be geared towards improving the standard of living of the disabled ones.

Mr Speaker, every year we do Statements to try to remind ourselves about the need to pay particular attention to disability issues. However, most of our structural designs, facilities, and a whole lot are still not walking the talk.

7.58 p.m.

Contractors and what have you, still put up modern structures without taking care of disability issues or implementing the right structures that will include the physically challenged being able to access them. So, as a society, we are usually at fault when some of these things are looked at and for me, we have to go on a national crusade. I know, day in day out, we talk about issues of disabilities, but as a Parliament, we may have to re-look at certain issues and close on this. I am sure the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection is going to fast track a Legislative Instrument (L.I.) on disability issues, so that we close the chapter on this.

Parliament has to look at the law. I know, as a member of the Disability Caucus, we have spoken about it. The people themselves are passionate about the need to finalise their L.I. so that they can be well included in our system. With these few words, Mr Speaker, I am grateful and I thank the maker of the Statement. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we will take one more contribution, then we will call it a day.

Being the House of seniority, I will give the floor to Mr Chiwitey.

Mr Andrew Dari Chiwitey (NDC— Sawla/Tuna/Kalba): I am most grateful for the opportunity to make a comment on Dr Apaak's ably delivered Statement.

Mr Speaker, most of the people living with disability are people we can always describe as smart people. I schooled at Nusrat Jahan Ahmadiyya College of Education in Wa, in the Upper West Region. I happened to school with a number of people living with disability. I can remember Justina, she was crippled but very intelligent. Mr Speaker, I can remember Phillip and Patrick; Phillip Patrick and were blind students, but they were the most intelligent in the class. You would not believe it. I happened to be the one who used to read for them. There was a challenge because they did not have all the facilities, especially braille machines, among others.

Mr Speaker, I think these are the things that we need to work out for such persons, those in the secondary schools, tertiary institutions, and at the basic level. In my constituency, I have a number of them, especially those in the basic level. There is a village called Taletuma in my constituency. There is this man who had twin boys, both of them are blind. It is a typical village, but the man managed to take them to school. As we speak, they are in Junior High School (JHS) in Wa. They are very intelligent students. Sometimes when I go to the village to campaign and I meet them, they become my voices.

Mr Speaker, but another challenge that is hindering the performance of students, especially those in the tertiary institutions and we have to look at as Members of Parliament is that most of the assemblies do not release the percentage of the Fund that is supposed to go to the people living with disabilities. They do not release them timely. Some do not even give them the three per cent that is supposed to go to them at all. Mr Speaker, we will be surprised to hear that some of those students would write letters to the assemblies and they would not release the funds to them.

Just in December, before the elections, I had the privilege to meet a group of them in Sawla. In fact, they are very productive, very united, and the complaint was just regarding the releases from the district assemblies to them. And so, Mr Speaker, I want to take this opportunity to urge that as a House, we pay attention to the percentage of the amount that is supposed to go to such persons. Let us ensure that the assemblies release such moneys to them. Sometimes, some of the women who just need tabletop fridges, or small freezers to do business that will help them take care of their kids. Some of the men repair watches, phones and need just as little as GH¢1000 or GH¢500.

So, I believe that if the assemblies are consistent in releasing the three per cent to the people living with disabilities, we will be solving a lot of problems. Mr Speaker, let me conclude, because I know we are tired, by appreciating one of my branch chairmen who is also a

Person with isability. We call him Dapla. That gentleman is disabled, but he is the smartest in that polling station. For me, I believe that if we give them the support, allow them to operate, give them that respect, give them the recognition, and make them feel part of the society, most of them can do far better than us because we are not better than them. We can all remember the gentleman who was made the Minister for Chieftaincy and Traditional Affairs, Dr Henry Seidu Daanaa. Who did better than him? Currently, President Mahama appointed one gentleman, a Frafra man called Adongo. During the campaign, he was travelling from Wa and had a breakdown in Sawla/Tuna/Kalba. Mr Speaker, fortunately, his vehicle broke down in the community where I have the disabled man as my branch chairman; a community called Blema.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, he is a Person with Disability, but not disabled.

Mr Chiwitey: Thank you. He is a Person with Disability. Mr Speaker, Mr Adongo's vehicle broke down in that community and I asked him to look for my branch chairman. When the branch chairman, who was also in that category was called in the night, he called me. He stood by Mr Adongo to ensure that Mr Adongo's vehicle was towed to Sawla where I got him accommodation, and he continued with his journey the next day. So, who said those who live with disabilities cannot perform? They can. Mr Speaker, let us join hands and especially, re-echo the release of the three per cent of the District Assemblies

Common Fund to them. I thank you so much for this opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Members. Persons with Disability are not disabled. Disability is also not inability. We have passed the disability law, but we should ask ourselves whether the law has been implemented to achieve its purpose. If you give me the opportunity, I will say that the disability law has not been fully implemented for the purpose for which we have passed the law.

Hon Members, Persons with Disability must be given equal and better opportunities in society. If three per cent of District Assemblies Common Fund is dedicated for Persons with Disability in a district, why would you keep this three per cent away from the Persons with Disability? There is no constituency that does not have Persons with Disability. It is for that reason that three per cent is dedicated for them. As to why Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) would not release this money to them, the least said about it, the better. I would urge the MMDCEs to ensure timely releases of the small percentage dedicated for Persons with Disability.

On this note, I would say that Statement time has ended and we have sat in excess of five hours. So, I will stand on Order 56 to adjourn the House.

Hon Members, the House is accordingly—

Mr Achemapong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

8.08 p.m.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I thank you for advising all of us as to how to proceed, but all the Members who contributed belong to either the Committee on Education or the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development. So, Mr Speaker, I want you to advise them that any time there is a report before them, they should ensure the 3 per cent is ceded to persons living with disabilities, so that if they are not given the money, we can monitor it.

Mr Speaker, when we talk about disability, we look far. Obesity is even a disability, but we think it is about people who have issues with their legs or hands or whatever, but some are hidden. Even stress levels can lead to disabilities, for one not to think right. Luckily the Minister made a Statement, so Members on both Committees should try to police it so that we can, at least, give true meaning to whatever we are giving to our young brothers and even adults. Some will grow to become adults—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, we should ensure—

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, tomorrow we will be starting at 10.00 a.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so let us all come together to ensure that the rights of persons with disability are protected. I am a Member of the Disability Caucus myself.

Hon Members, I have this announcement on the inauguration of Parliamentary Friendship Association.

ANNOUNCEMENT

Inauguration of Parliamentary Friendship Associations

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Rt Hon Speaker of Parliament would tomorrow, Friday, 27th June, 2025, inaugurate 42 Parliamentary Friendship Associations duly recognised in the Ninth Parliament in the Chamber of Parliament at 9.00 a.m.

Members of the Diplomatic Corps of countries of respective Friendship Associations have been invited to the

ceremony and are expected to be seated by 8.40 a.m. Hon Members are accordingly entreated to also be seated by 8.40 a.m.

Thank you very much.

Hon Members, the House is accordingly adjourned to Friday, 27th June, 2025, at 10.00 a.m. in the forenoon.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 8.12 p.m. till Friday, 27th June, 2025 at 10.00 a.m.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 8th July, 2025.

Column 10, last paragraph, line 8, "Six" was replaced with "Four".